International Labour Organization

Measuring Cooperatives

An information guide on the ILO guidelines concerning statistics of cooperatives

Second edition

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International Labour Organization. Geneva

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Preface

2025 is the second United Nations International Year of Cooperatives. As the world faces numerous interrelated economic, social and environmental challenges, cooperatives continue to contribute to the sustainability of societies at local, national, regional and global levels.

Statistics on cooperatives can provide evidence on the contribution of cooperatives to decent work and sustainable development. Currently, such statistics are often collected by cooperative associations, and/or by government agencies regulating cooperatives. However, this is not done in a comparable and harmonized manner. In many instances, cooperatives are not included in national statistical frameworks of the statistics offices.

To overcome these challenges, the ILO, in collaboration with its constituents and a number of national and international partners, has been working towards developing guidelines on the measurement of cooperatives. These efforts led to the adoption of the *Guidelines concerning Statistics of Cooperatives* at the 20th International Conference of Labour Statisticians (ICLS) which were then approved by the Governing Body of the ILO in March 2019. The Guidelines are the first international statistical standard on cooperatives. They cover concepts and definitions around cooperatives, types of cooperatives, statistical units, work in cooperatives, and ways of collecting, tabulating, and analysing statistical data on cooperatives.

The objective of this information guide is to provide practical guidance for the ILO's Member States toward implementing the Guidelines. It is one of the activities undertaken as part of an initiative on the statistics of cooperatives. In 2025, it was updated based on findings from five countries that compared the international guidelines with their national contexts and practices concerning statistics of cooperatives.

A deliverable under a project funded by the government of the Republic of Korea, we hope this revised information guide is useful for staff in national statistics offices, and researchers working in and on cooperatives. It is our hope that they will use this revised guide to test the concepts and definitions presented in the Guidelines, develop measures that assess the economic contribution of cooperatives and undertake further methodological work related to statistics of cooperatives.

At the ILO we are committed to advancing statistics on cooperatives to better understand and advance the role of cooperatives in helping build a human-centred future of work.

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The revised information guide benefited from inputs from Simel Esim, Nawon Lee, Madita Rabe, and Yiqing Zhou at the ILO's Cooperative, Social and Solidarity Economy Unit.

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Acronyms and abbreviations

C063	Convention concerning Statistics of Wages and Hours of Work, 1938 (No. 63)
C160	Labour Statistics Convention, 1985 (No. 160)
CICOPA	International Organization of Industrial, Artisanal and Service Producer Cooperatives
COPAC	Committee for the Promotion and Advancement of Cooperatives
ICLS	International Conference of Labour Statisticians
ICSE	International Classification of Status in Employment
ILC	International Labour Conference
ILO	International Labour Organization
LFS	Labour Force Survey
NPI	Non-Profit Institution
SNA	System of National Accounts
UN	United Nations

1. Introduction – Cooperatives and international standards for labour statistics

What is this information guide?

This second edition of the information guide provides updated information for a wide-ranging audience about the Guidelines concerning Statistics of Cooperatives adopted at the 20th International Conference of Labour Statisticians (ICLS) in October 2018 (ILO 2018a). The Guidelines were developed in response to a resolution adopted at the 19th ICLS in 2013 which recommended that the International Labour Office carry out further developmental work on the statistical measurement of cooperatives. They are the first international statistical standard dealing specifically with statistics on cooperatives.

The Guidelines describe the concepts, statistical units, definitions and classifications needed to produce internationally comparable statistics on cooperatives, types of cooperatives, members of cooperatives and work in cooperatives. They refer to existing international statistical standards relevant for the production of statistics on these topics, including the System of National Accounts (SNA), the 19th ICLS Resolution concerning statistics of work, employment and labour underutilization, and the revised International Classification of Status in Employment (ICSE-18) adopted as part of the 20th ICLS Resolution concerning statistics on work relationships.

Why this guide?

Whilst the Guidelines provide information on ways of tabulating and analysing statistical data on cooperatives, they do not explain the reasons why things are defined as they are or provide comprehensive information on putting the Guidelines into practice. They emphasize the need for more methodological work and testing in relation to data collection, and on measurement of the economic contribution of cooperatives.

At the time of writing the first edition of this information guide, much of this methodological work was yet to be done. It did not, therefore, describe the operational steps required to collect, analyse and disseminate statistics on cooperatives. Since that time, several countries have gained experience in compiling statistics aligned with the Guidelines, including through an ILO initiative on advancing the Guidelines, funded by the Government of the Republic of Korea. This initiative primarily involved evaluating and making recommendations on the information specified in the Guidelines across five countries (Costa Rica, Italy, the Republic of Korea, Türkiye, and the United Republic of Tanzania). The results of these five national studies, as well as a global report which summarizes the results of these studies, have been released in a compendium publication *Implementing the ILO Guidelines Concerning Statistics of Cooperatives: Insights from five countries*.

The applicability and relevance of the Guidelines were well demonstrated through these case studies. The experience gained in implementing the Guidelines has allowed the information guide to be updated to clarify certain aspects of the Guidelines, and to improve the guidance on implementation in line with the findings of the national studies. This revised edition of the information guide:

- explains why there is a need for reliable and comparable statistics on cooperatives;
- discusses how the Guidelines can be used to support the production of statistics on cooperatives;
- provides advice about known good practices and clarification of the Guidelines where necessary.

This information guide is not, however, a detailed manual on the implementation of the Guidelines. This requires more experience, particularly in relation to measuring the distinctive economic contribution of cooperatives and their social, cultural and environmental impact. The ILO plans to develop a comprehensive manual on statistics of cooperatives based primarily on information gained from:

- exchanges with a community of practice on statistics of cooperatives hosted by the ILO;
- the outputs of a Committee on the Promotion and Advancement of Cooperatives (COPAC) technical working group on measuring the economic contribution of cooperatives;
- work to be commissioned by the ILO to develop indicators to measure their social, cultural and environmental impact.

The ILO also plans to develop training materials on the implementation of the standards for statistics of cooperatives and update these materials progressively as data collection and compilation methods are developed. More detailed information on each of these initiatives is provided in the compendium publication *Implementing the ILO Guidelines Concerning Statistics of Cooperatives: Insights from five countries.*

Who is this guide for?

This guide provides information for those involved in national processes of testing and developing methods to implement the Guidelines, including those participating in the ILO community of practice on statistics of cooperatives. Insights and experiences from these national testing and development processes will ultimately provide the practical information and experience needed to enable the development of the manual on the collection and compilation of statistics of cooperatives described above. Bearing this in mind, the guide is intended for:

- staff in national statistics offices, government agencies responsible for cooperatives and cooperative federations who want to undertake methodological work to develop and improve statistics on cooperatives in accordance with the Guidelines;
- members of the cooperative movement who want a better understanding of statistics on cooperatives and how they can be improved;
- users of statistics on cooperatives who want an overview of what the statistics collected according to the Guidelines can measure.

What is the ILO?

The International Labour Organization (ILO) is the specialized agency of the United Nations (UN) which deals with the world of work. It brings together governments, employers and workers from 187 member States, to set labour standards, develop policies and devise programmes promoting decent work for all.

The ILO was created in 1919, as part of the Treaty of Versailles that ended World War I, to reflect the belief that universal and lasting peace can be accomplished only if it is based on social justice.

It became the first specialized agency of the newly formed UN in 1946. With its base in Geneva, it has a network of offices in more than 40 countries.

Each part of the UN system is responsible for a particular area – its mandate, in UN jargon. The ILO's mandate is social questions – especially the world of work and employment. So, workplace relations, child labour, vocational training, policy on employment creation, health and safety at work and, of course, cooperatives and the wider social and solidarity economy are some of the many issues dealt with by the ILO. The ILO's Decent Work Agenda helps advance the economic and working conditions that give all workers, employers and governments a stake in lasting peace, prosperity and progress.

Like all UN organizations, the ILO is financed by its Member States. Countries have to join the ILO separately. Not all countries that are members of the United Nations are members of the ILO.

The ILO accomplishes its work through three main bodies composed of representatives of governments, employers, and workers.

- The International Labour Conference sets the international labour standards and the broad policies of the ILO. It meets annually in Geneva and is also a forum for discussion of key social and labour questions.
- The Governing Body is the executive council of the ILO. It meets three times a year in Geneva. It takes decisions on ILO policy and establishes the programme and the budget, which it then submits to the Conference for adoption.
- The International Labour Office is the permanent secretariat of the ILO. It is the focal point for ILO's overall activities, which it prepares under the scrutiny of the Governing Body and under the leadership of the Director-General.

Tripartism and social dialogue

The importance of "tripartism" – cooperation between governments and employers' and workers' organizations – lies at the heart of the way the ILO works.

The ILO encourages tripartism within its constituents – employers' organizations, workers' organizations and Member States – by promoting social dialogue between representative organizations of employers and workers and governments on a variety of topics related to the world of work, including, where appropriate, the formulation and implementation of national policies on social, economic, and other issues. In some countries, for example, Viet Nam and South Africa, the cooperative movement is included as a partner in the social dialogue mechanisms.

The work of the ILO Governing Body and of the International Labour Office is aided by tripartite committees covering major industries. It is also supported by committees, meetings of experts and working groups on such matters as vocational training, management development, occupational safety and health, industrial relations, workers' education, special problems of women and young workers, and statistics.

What are international labour standards?

Since 1919, the International Labour Organization has maintained and developed a system of international labour standards. These standards aim to promote opportunities for all to obtain decent and productive work in conditions of freedom, equity, security and dignity. In today's globalized economy, international labour standards are an essential component in the international framework for ensuring that the global economy provides benefits to all.

International labour standards are legal instruments drawn up by the ILO's constituents setting out basic principles and rights at work. They are either Conventions or Recommendations. Conventions are legally binding international treaties that can be ratified by Member States, while Recommendations are non-binding guidelines. In many cases, a Convention lays down the basic principles to be implemented by countries that have ratified it. A related Recommendation provides more detailed guidance on how it could be applied. Recommendations can also be autonomous, meaning that they are not linked to a Convention (ILO 2019).

International labour standards evolve from a growing international concern that action needs to be taken on a particular issue, such as providing working women with maternity protection, or ensuring safe working conditions for agricultural workers. They represent the international consensus on how a particular labour problem could be addressed at the global level and reflect knowledge and experience from all corners of the world.

The Promotion of Cooperatives Recommendation, 2002 (No. 193)

The Promotion of Cooperatives Recommendation, 2002 (No. 193) recognizes the role of cooperatives in job creation, mobilizing resources and generating investment. It is an autonomous recommendation in the sense that it is not linked to a particular convention (ILO 2019). Key points of the Recommendation include the following:

- Cooperatives operate in all sectors.
- Measures should be adopted to promote the potential of cooperatives in all countries.
- Cooperatives are based on principles and values.
- The International Cooperative Alliance (ICA) Statement on the Cooperative Identity states what these values and principles are and provides the generally accepted definition of a cooperative.
- Cooperatives should enjoy equal treatment with other types of enterprise.
- Governments should create an enabling environment and facilitate access to support services.
- Employers' and workers' organizations should promote cooperatives.
- Cooperatives should cooperate internationally.

Importantly for the purposes of this Guide, the Recommendation articulates the need to improve national statistics on cooperatives with a view to supporting the formulation and implementation of development policies.

International standards and guidelines for labour statistics

Labour statistics are an important part of the ILO's work. High quality and internationally comparable statistics are essential to provide information on virtually all the issues the ILO is dealing with in the world of work. The ILO's Department of Statistics focuses on four major activities:

- compiling and producing labour statistics, which are disseminated through ILOSTAT;
- setting international standards for labour statistics through the International Conference of Labour Statisticians (ICLS);
- providing capacity building and assistance in labour statistics;
- research and development.

International standards for labour statistics include Conventions and Recommendations adopted by the International Labour Conference (ILC), but also include Resolutions and Guidelines adopted by the International Conference of Labour Statisticians (ICLS).

One Convention is currently in force in the field of labour statistics and forms part of the International Labour Code:

- C160 – Labour Statistics Convention, 1985 (No. 160)

Each of the countries that have ratified the Labour Statistics Convention is required to report to the ILO on their application. The Department of Statistics then makes a technical evaluation of the situation, on the basis of which the Governing Body's Committee of Experts on the Application of Conventions and Recommendations follows up on problems or queries with the countries concerned. Currently, 53 countries have ratified Convention No. 160.

The ILC has also adopted R170 - Labour Statistics Recommendation, 1985 (No. 170). It is a non-binding instrument, which provides further guidance regarding the frequency of data collection, recommended disaggregation of the statistics, and national statistical infrastructures.

The International Conference of Labour Statisticians (ICLS)

The ICLS is a vehicle for standard-setting in labour statistics, hosted by the ILO every five years. Participants include experts from governments, mostly from ministries responsible for labour and from national statistical offices, as well as from employers' and workers' organizations. Regional and international organizations and other interest groups attend as observers.

The ICLS makes recommendations on selected topics of labour statistics in the form of resolutions and guidelines, which are then approved by the Governing Body of the ILO before becoming part of the body of international statistical standards. These standards usually relate to concepts, definitions, classifications, and other methodological procedures which are agreed as representing 'best practice' in the respective areas.

Resolutions provide detailed guidance on conceptual frameworks, operational definitions, and measurement methodologies to produce and disseminate the various labour statistics. They are used by national producers of statistics to develop or revise their national labour statistics programmes and to enhance international comparability. Guidelines provide more general guidance relating to particular areas of interest.

The task of standard-setting in labour statistics begins with a review by the Department of Statistics of the concepts, definitions, classifications and methods currently used by countries, in order to identify problems and develop possible approaches for their solution. Many producers and users of the statistics are consulted throughout each development stage. A technical working group made up of national and international experts may be established to support the ILO in the development work. A formal meeting of experts is usually convened, with experts appointed by the Governing Body in consultation with governments, employers' organizations, and workers' organizations. This group examines the issues and makes recommendations, on the basis of which the Department prepares proposals for the ICLS to consider.

This process was followed to develop the Guidelines concerning Statistics of Cooperatives. The ILO with the Committee for the Promotion and Advancement of Cooperatives (COPAC) conducted desk reviews of national practices on statistics of cooperatives. The reviews included countries with different types of institutional arrangements for producing statistics on cooperatives. They examined how statistics on cooperatives are generated, the definitions used and what statistics were available. A technical working group on statistics for cooperatives was established, consisting of representatives of the cooperative movement, national statistical offices, policymakers and researchers. The technical working group initiated and discussed a number of studies that provided inputs into the preparation of the draft guidelines.

The global report of the ILO initiative on advancing the Guidelines concerning statistics of cooperatives in five countries was presented and discussed at the 21st ICLS in November 2023. The conference was supportive of the strategy outlined in that paper for further work to support countries in implementing the Guidelines. The various elements in this strategy are described in more detail in the ILO compendium publication *Implementing the ILO Guidelines Concerning Statistics of Cooperatives: Insights from five countries* and include the following:

- revision of the ILO information guide: Measuring Cooperatives, to reflect the findings of the country studies (this document);
- establishment of a community of practice on statistics of cooperatives;
- establishment of a technical working group on measuring the economic contribution of cooperatives;
- undertaking research to develop a framework and statistical methods to measure the social, cultural and environmental impacts of cooperatives.

▶ 2. What is so important about the Guidelines concerning statistics of cooperatives?

Why cooperatives?

The role of cooperatives in job creation and local economic development is widely recognized. Cooperatives have a unique and special role in promoting sustainable economic growth, high quality employment, decent work and social justice. This is because the cooperative ownership model and democratic governance principles ensure that the activities of cooperatives are driven by the needs of their members as producers, workers, consumers, and members of society.

The cooperative model provides a means for producers, workers and consumers to address many of the challenges they face in the rapidly changing world of work and in society more generally. These challenges include demographic changes, aging, migration, climate change and the advances in technology that are impacting heavily on both the nature and organization of work. The areas in which the cooperative model is considered to have a particularly beneficial effect include, but are not limited to:

- the transition from informal to formal economic activities and employment;
- addressing growing inequalities in terms of access to housing, services and well-paid employment;
- the re-organization and flexibilization of work deriving, at least in part, from technological development.

There are several studies and publications that provide evidence on both the potential and the achievements of cooperatives in addressing these challenges and in promoting equitable and sustainable growth[1] as well as economic resilience and stability during crises. However, for a full assessment to inform policy on the promotion and regulation of cooperatives and other types of enterprises, comprehensive statistical information is needed on the contribution and role of cooperatives in promoting:

- economic growth;
- economic resilience and stability;
- sustainable development, especially in agriculture;
- employment and decent work;
- transition from the informal to the formal economy;
- re-organization and flexibilization of work reflecting technological change and the future of work;
- equitable and affordable access to housing, social and financial services.

1 For example Transforming our world: A cooperative 2030 series produced by COPAC

The second global report on employment in cooperatives published by the International Organization of Industrial, Artisanal and Service Producer Cooperatives (CICOPA) in 2017 estimated that at least 279.4 million people were employed in or within the scope of cooperatives. That is more than 9 per cent of the world's employed population (Eum 2017).

The ILO Promotion of Cooperatives Recommendation, 2002 (No. 193) stresses the need to improve national statistics on cooperatives to help develop and implement policies to promote cooperatives. The United Nations 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development confirms the role of cooperatives as a means of implementation towards achieving the goals (UN 2015, para. 41).

Cooperatives and the wider social and solidarity economy (SSE)

Cooperatives form an important part of the SSE, which also - depending on national contexts - includes associations, mutual societies, foundations, social enterprises, self-help groups and other entities, operating in accordance with the values and principles of the SSE. The need to "improve statistics of the SSE such as through satellite accounts and collaboration between national statistical institutes and SSE institutional representatives, to inform the formulation and implementation of policies" was stressed by the International Labour Conference in June 2022, in its Resolution concerning decent work and the social and solidarity economy (ILC.110/Resolution II, para 9). The Strategy and Action Plan (2023-29) adopted by the ILO Governing Body in 2022 included among its objectives the development of international guidelines on statistics concerning the SSE (GB.346/INS/3/2). Considering both the similarities and differences between cooperatives and other entities in the SSE, statistics compiled based on the Guidelines will thus be a step towards, and ultimately form part of, a wider set of statistics encompassing all elements of the SSE.

Work to develop standardized concepts and methods for the compilation of statistics on the wider SSE is planned to be undertaken in parallel with the ongoing work on the development of statistics of cooperatives. This work will be led by a United Nations Inter-Agency Task Force on Social and Solidarity Economy (UNTFSSE) Technical Working Group on Social and Solidarity Economy Statistics.

Towards a harmonized set of global statistics on cooperatives

The Guidelines were developed in response to the need for improved availability of statistics on cooperatives at the global level that are comparable between countries and coherent with related economic and labour market statistics. The statistics specified in the Guidelines are not, however, intended to disrupt or replace existing national statistics of cooperatives, but rather to provide a framework to promote internationally comparable, robust, and comprehensive statistics on cooperatives. While countries may need to adapt and adjust their data collections, collect new information, or use new data sources to compile statistics aligned with the Guidelines, existing data collections and time series that are considered useful for national purposes should not be discontinued or disrupted.

Implementing the ILO Guidelines should not, therefore, break existing methodologies but should be adapted to strengthen the statistics already developed over the years at the national level. It is expected, however, that in most countries implementation of the Guidelines will improve both quality, comprehensiveness and comparability of national statistics. Statistics from multiple sources will be required to comprehensively inform national policies on cooperatives and provide internationally comparable information. Statistics from a single type of source cannot provide a complete picture of the contribution of cooperatives to the economy, the labour market and society, as specified in the Guidelines.

Good quality statistics on cooperatives can be collected from cooperatives themselves and may be compiled from sources such as administrative registrations, and censuses or surveys of institutions registered as cooperatives.

Information about cooperatives and work in cooperatives is included in mainstream official economic and social statistics, compiled by national statistical agencies. These statistics are drawn from sources such as censuses and surveys of businesses and households conducted by national statistical offices or other agencies responsible for official statistics on a particular topic, and from administrative sources such as company registers. They are based on internationally agreed concepts, definitions and methodologies which allow information from different sources and countries to be harmonized, integrated and compared. In many countries, however, the data pertaining to cooperatives in these statistics cannot be separately identified from other types of enterprises.

The relevant sources of official statistics include:

- administrative and statistical business registers;
- censuses and surveys of enterprises;
- household surveys, especially on topics such as the labour force, household income and expenditure and housing.

Statistics from the cooperative movement

In many countries statistics on cooperatives are mainly produced by cooperative confederations or government agencies responsible for cooperatives. These statistics cover topics such as the number and types of cooperatives, the number of members of cooperatives, the number of employees working in cooperatives and economic performance (such as value added, turnover, equity and assets). They can provide an important part of the statistical picture on cooperatives and may in some cases be considered as part of the official national statistics of a country.

However, statistics on cooperatives compiled by these agencies are not usually fully comparable with official statistics on the wider economy and the labour market, or with statistics from other countries. They are not always produced on a regular basis and may vary with respect to the scope of the data collected. Because the source of information is the cooperatives themselves, they can usually provide only relatively basic information, such as age and sex, about people who work in cooperatives, or are members of cooperatives.

A census of cooperatives, which is a specific type of establishment census, could collect much of the detailed information needed to compile statistics on types of cooperatives, along with other rich information on their employment, members, memberships, and economic contribution. Censuses of cooperatives are likely to be conducted by cooperative federations or government agencies responsible for cooperatives, rather than by national statistical offices. Harmonization of the content of censuses of cooperatives with the content included in economic censuses and surveys would allow statistics compiled from them to be compared usefully with the statistics on the whole economy compiled by national statistical offices. Collaboration between the agency conducting the census of cooperatives and the national statistical office during the development of the census of cooperatives on data content and methodological issues would be essential if these types of harmonization are to be achieved.

Business registers

Administrative registers of enterprises are maintained by governments, or by cooperative confederations, for administrative purposes. Statistical business registers are maintained by national statistical offices and typically combine information from multiple administrative registers as well as from censuses and surveys. Statistical procedures are used for cleaning and integration of the data included in statistical business registers based on standardized metadata and formats. These registers are used to define the population to be enumerated in economic censuses and surveys and, in the case of surveys, to create the sample frame. Data from such censuses and surveys, as well as from administrative sources, are typically used to validate and update the information held in the statistical registers, including the removal of inactive units.

In general, administrative and statistical registers can provide information about the numbers and basic characteristics of enterprises but not about economic performance or employment, as these are characteristics that change over time. In some countries, employment registers maintained by government agencies can be used to identify employment and certain characteristics of persons employed in cooperatives, such as age, sex and country of origin.

Censuses and surveys of businesses

Establishment censuses and surveys are statistical data collections that collect data directly from businesses (establishments) and provide extensive information about the characteristics of businesses. They are the main sources of information about the economic performance of businesses.

An establishment census is an exhaustive data collection method covering all establishments, or a specific subset of establishments, in a country. For example, a census of agriculture is a statistical operation for collecting, processing and disseminating data on the structure of agriculture, covering the whole or a significant part of a country (FAO 2015, 3). A census of cooperatives is a type of establishment census covering institutions that are registered as cooperatives.

An establishment survey collects data from a representative sample of establishments. Some establishment surveys, frequently referred to as "business surveys", aim primarily to measure production and the economic performance of businesses. Other establishment surveys are mainly concerned with the measurement of employment and earnings. Like establishment censuses, some establishment surveys collect data from a sample of all establishments in the country, while others cover only establishments in some economic sectors.

Establishments can provide detailed information on their own characteristics (establishment size, economic activity, production, etc.). They can provide reliable data on the number of workers on their payrolls and on characteristics of their jobs such as wages and working time. However, they can generally provide only basic demographic information about the characteristics of the workers themselves, such as age and sex.

Household surveys

Household surveys collect data directly from members of households using the household as the sampling unit. The data may be collected through personal interviews conducted in the household or by telephone interview, frequently using computer assisted interviewing technology which allows complex sequencing of questions depending on the response to questions already asked. Self-enumerated questionnaires may also be used, using paper forms to be mailed back or completed electronically. In some surveys, the information is provided by one member of the household as a proxy on behalf of the other members. In other cases, each member of the household is interviewed

separately, or only a selection of members of the household is interviewed. This depends on the sensitivity of the information being collected and the likelihood that one household member would be able to provide the types of information requested about other members of the household. Both the mode of collection and the use of proxies will have an impact on the nature of the information that can be collected.

Household surveys are the main sources of statistics about people, their jobs, the number of jobs held by each person, the characteristics of their jobs such as status in employment and occupation, and about their social, demographic and economic characteristics as well as those of their families and households. They can provide basic information about the characteristics of the establishments in which household members are employed. Labour force surveys (LFS), general and multi-purpose household surveys and income and expenditure surveys all provide information that could be used to assess the economic, social and labour market impacts of cooperatives – except that they rarely collect information about whether a person works in a cooperative or is a member of a cooperative.

Harmonization of data from different sources

The compilation of comprehensive statistics about cooperatives would require the use of data from all these different types of data sources. No single type of source can provide statistics on the number and types of cooperatives, their economic performance, membership, the employment they generate, and the characteristics of members and of the people who work in cooperatives. If different concepts, definitions and methodologies are used in the different sources, the statistics compiled from these sources will not be comparable.

Currently, however, the contribution of cooperatives is rarely identified in official statistics produced by national statistical offices. Despite their economic and social significance, little attention has been given until recently to cooperatives in international statistical standards.

The Guidelines concerning statistics of cooperatives are an important step towards addressing these problems. Cooperative associations and agencies can use them to improve the comparability of statistics from different data sources and improve consistency and harmonization with mainstream economic and labour statistics. National statistical offices and other agencies producing official statistics can use the Guidelines to improve the identification of information related to cooperatives in relevant data sources. This would allow the provision of a coherent, wide and comparable range of statistics to assess the contribution of cooperatives to the economy, labour market and society, including those compiled by cooperative associations and agencies.

3. Overview of the Guidelines concerning statistics of cooperatives

The Guidelines describe the concepts, classifications, statistical units, and definitions needed to compile statistics on cooperatives in a way that is consistent with the current international standards for economic and labour statistics. They stress that statistics on cooperatives should provide information for descriptive, analytical and policy purposes and that this requires information on:

- number and types of cooperatives
- members of cooperatives
- work generated in cooperatives
- economic contribution of cooperatives

The Guidelines also specify the statistical units relevant for the production of statistics about cooperatives. "Statistical units" are the entities from which or about which statistics on cooperatives can be collected and compiled. The basic statistical units specified are:

- cooperatives
- members of cooperatives
- persons
- jobs or work activities
- the institutional units defined in the System of National Accounts (2008 SNA) and the International Standard Industrial Classification of All Economic Activities, Revision 4 (ISIC, Rev. 4)

Reference concepts and definitions provided in the Guidelines describe what it is that the statistics should aim to measure for the analytical purposes identified. Operational definitions describe the information that can feasibly be obtained in data collections to provide sufficiently accurate measurement of these concepts. The Guidelines provide reference concepts and operational definitions for cooperatives, types of cooperatives, members of cooperatives, and work generated in cooperatives. The other statistical units are defined in existing international statistical standards. Job or work activity is defined in paragraph 12(b) of the 21st ICLS Resolution to amend the 19th ICLS resolution concerning statistics of work, employment and labour underutilization as a "set of tasks and duties performed, or meant to be performed, by one person for a single economic unit..." (ILO 2023).

The part of the Guidelines on operational definitions and statistical units lists operational criteria which define cooperatives and provides guidance on the treatment of entities which either share some of the characteristics of cooperatives or are related to cooperatives. As there is no agreed methodology to measure the economic contribution of cooperatives, the Guidelines do not provide detailed definitions for this aspect but stress that the ILO should work in collaboration with interested parties on the development of measures to assess this.

Cooperatives

The reference concept of cooperatives defined in the Guidelines is derived from the legal definition in ILO Recommendation No. 193, with the clarification that membership can include both physical persons and legal persons or entities:

> A cooperative is defined as an autonomous association of persons and/or legal entities united voluntarily to meet their common economic, social and cultural needs and aspirations through a jointly owned and democratically controlled enterprise.

This definition describes the key elements and main purpose of cooperatives: to meet the needs of their members. Such needs include, for example, access to markets and greater income stability for members who commercialize their production through a cooperative; reasonable prices for members of consumer cooperatives; access to employment or better working conditions for members of a workers' cooperative; or access to tools and machinery for a producers' cooperative.

The Guidelines also clarify the relationship between cooperatives and the types of institutional unit defined in the System of National Accounts (SNA) that can include cooperatives. Within the SNA, cooperatives are corporations (financial or non-financial) or non-profit institutions (NPIs). A cooperative is treated as an NPI if its articles of association prevent it from distributing any of its profits to its members (UN 2008a, paras 4.7 and 23.21). This helps to identify where cooperatives might be found in existing economic statistics based on the SNA.

For measurement purposes, the Guidelines state that the definition of cooperatives can be operationalized on the basis of four criteria. These are fundamental defining characteristics of cooperatives. Any enterprise that does not meet each of these criteria should not be defined as a cooperative for statistical purposes:

- A cooperative should be a formally established institutional unit (non-financial corporation, financial corporation or non-profit institution).
- A cooperative should be controlled democratically by its members according to the principle that each member has an equal vote.
- Membership of the cooperative should be voluntary and non-restrictive.
- Distribution of profits or surpluses among the members is not directly linked to the capital contributed by each member.

The Guidelines recognize, however, that in some instances enterprises may operate in a similar way to cooperatives without being registered formally as cooperatives. Such enterprises are sometimes referred to as "informal cooperatives". The Guidelines specify that unregistered cooperatives should be identified separately, based on the last three criteria listed above. However, it is important to consider that the term "unregistered cooperatives" can refer to two different types of enterprise. Firstly, formal sector enterprises may function as cooperatives but are registered for one reason or another with a status other than a cooperative. Secondly, informal sector enterprises may function as cooperatives but are not formally registered as a business. Methods for identification and measurement of such unregistered entities operating according to cooperative principles will be addressed in the context of the development of statistics of the social and solidarity economy, taking the statistical standards specified in the Resolution concerning statistics on the informal economy adopted at the 21st ICLS into consideration.

The Guidelines also note that mutual societies, self-help groups or social ventures (as defined in the SNA) should not be counted as cooperatives.

The Guidelines stress that statistics of cooperatives should include statistics on subsidiaries that are not cooperatives, such as incorporated enterprises owned or controlled by cooperatives, and on enterprises that are members of cooperatives. To the extent possible, statistics should be compiled separately for cooperatives, enterprises that are members of cooperatives and enterprises that are owned and controlled by cooperatives. Such statistics are referred to as "statistics within the scope" of cooperatives. This broad scope is considered essential to allow a full assessment of the economic and social contribution of cooperatives.

Types of cooperatives

Since the needs of members are central to understanding the nature and contribution of cooperatives, the Guidelines define four main types of cooperatives based on the main interest of their members:

- producer cooperatives
- worker cooperatives
- consumer/user cooperatives
- multi-stakeholder cooperatives

The Guidelines provide brief definitions of each of these types, summarized below.

This four-class typology is essentially a simplification and rationalization of the various typologies of cooperatives used by countries. It allows the comparison and aggregation of data on cooperatives in a consistent way at national and international levels. Like the operational definition of cooperatives, the typology in the Guidelines is based on the economic model of the cooperative, as it reflects the members' main economic interest in the cooperative, which relates to how the cooperative is expected to behave with regard to its transactions with members (and hence also to how its economic contribution should be measured).[2]

▶ **Table 1. Types of cooperatives and their members**

Type of cooperative	Members' interest	Types of member
Producer cooperative	Production activity	Producer-members
Worker cooperative	Work	Worker-members
Consumer/user cooperative	Consumption	Consumer-members: clients, family of clients, non-profit institutions, producers, corporations
Multi-stakeholder cooperative	More than one members' interest	Producer-members, consumer-members, worker-members

In a **producer cooperative**, the main interest of the members is related to their production activity as enterprises in their own right. The members typically comprise household market enterprises such as small agricultural or craft producers but may also include corporations. Various subtypes of producer cooperatives may be identified such as "marketing cooperatives", "processing cooperatives", "supply or purchasing cooperatives", "cooperatives for management of assets" and "multi-purpose cooperatives" (Bouchard et al. 2020, 18).

2 See: Eum, Hyungsik, Chiara Carini and Marie J. Bouchard (2020), "Classification of cooperatives, a proposed typology", pp. 13-22 in Bouchard et al. 2020.

There are two different kinds of members' relationships to producer cooperatives: upstream of the cooperative's activity (the producer's products or services are provided as inputs to the cooperative's productive activity) and downstream of the cooperative's activity (cooperatives provide products or services to producers' productive activity). Some producer cooperatives have both functions. In its transactions with its members, the cooperative will tend to offer prices and marketing conditions that are equal to or higher than those prevailing in the market.

In general, federations and confederations of cooperatives that are themselves registered as cooperatives (apex cooperatives) should be classified as producer cooperatives. Their members are cooperatives which are enterprises in their own right, and the function of the apex cooperative is to provide products or services to its members.

In a **worker cooperative**, members share an interest in the work which is provided by or ensured through the cooperative. The members are individual workers (worker-members) whose jobs are directly assured through their cooperative. The cooperative will tend to offer its members remuneration and working conditions equal to or better than those prevailing in the market. This grouping also includes worker cooperatives that, in some countries, are named based on the economic activities carried out by the cooperative, such as "health cooperative" (Brazil), "common exploitation of land cooperative" (Spain), "agricultural work cooperative" (Italy), "agricultural cooperative-collective farm" and "cooperative farm" (Russia) (Bouchard et al. 2020, 18).

In a **consumer/user cooperative**, members are the consumers or users of the goods or services made available by or through the cooperative. The members' relation to the cooperative is downstream of the cooperative's activity. The cooperative will tend to offer prices and consumption conditions equal to or below market prices in its transactions with its members. Various subtypes of consumer cooperatives can be identified based on the nature of their activities, such as "consumer cooperative" (retail), "housing tenants' cooperative" and "utility cooperative" (water supply, electricity supply, telecommunication). Financial service cooperatives are classified as part of consumer/user cooperatives even when they primarily serve producers.

A **multi-stakeholder cooperative** is a cooperative which has more than one type of member with significant involvement in the activity of the cooperative and in which:

- more than one type of member is represented in the governance structure of the cooperative;
- no type of member has a dominant position through a majority of votes in the governing body or an exclusive veto over decisions.

This does not mean that to include a cooperative in this category, members of different types must have equal representation in its governance or management structure. Some types of members may have higher levels of representation than others, without necessarily having a majority of votes in the governing body or an exclusive veto over decisions. If more than one type of member of a cooperative has a veto over decisions, then it is likely that it should be included in this category. If this is not the case, the cooperative should be classified based on the type of member that has a majority of votes in the governing body, or an exclusive veto over decisions.

This classification of cooperatives based on the main interest of members should, of course, be complemented by classification based on other relevant characteristics, including the branch of economic activity (industry). The Guidelines note that statistics of cooperatives should be systematically tabulated as follows:

- by the four main types of cooperatives as well as by nationally specific subtypes where relevant and feasible;
- by branch of economic activity;
- by regions relevant to national purposes, including urban and rural areas.

A more comprehensive discussion of the classification of cooperatives can be found in Chapter 2 of *Statistics on cooperatives: Concepts, classification, work and economic contribution measurement* (Bouchard et al. 2020).

Members of cooperatives

According to the Guidelines, members of cooperatives may be persons or legal entities. This means that a member may either be an individual person or an institutional unit such as an enterprise. Membership should be open to all persons and entities able to use the services of a cooperative and willing to accept the responsibilities of membership, without gender, social, racial, political, or religious discrimination.

"Membership" is defined as the number of members of each cooperative. Both persons and legal entities can be members of more than one cooperative. Statistics on memberships are not, therefore, equivalent to statistics on the number of people and enterprises that are members of at least one cooperative. However, statistics about the number of members in an individual cooperative, or of particular types of cooperatives, may be useful in assessing their size, significance and impact, but can easily be misinterpreted if they are assumed to refer to the number of persons who are members of at least one cooperative.

Based on the main interests of the members, the Guidelines propose a threefold typology that is also reflected in the four cooperative types: producer-members, worker-members, and consumer-members. Producer-members are enterprises, although some enterprises may be indistinguishable from the person who owns them. Worker-members are, by definition, individual workers who work in the cooperative they own as worker-members. Consumer-members may be natural persons or institutional units such as corporations, unincorporated enterprises and non-profit institutions.

Work in cooperatives

Work performed in cooperatives can be undertaken by both members and non-members. It may include all forms of work defined in the Resolution concerning statistics of work, employment and labour underutilization adopted by the 19th ICLS. These forms of work are own-use production work, employment, volunteer work, unpaid trainee work and other forms of work.

The statistics on work generated by cooperatives, particularly in employment, should be compiled and tabulated separately for work performed by members and non-members in:

- cooperatives;
- economic units that are members of a producer cooperative or multi-stakeholder cooperative;
- subsidiary enterprises owned or controlled by a cooperative.

This inclusive and broad concept of work generated by cooperatives may be considered as "work within the scope of statistics on cooperatives".

The Guidelines explain the various circumstances in which producer-members and consumer-members may perform work in their own cooperatives, as volunteers, independent workers or employees. Importantly, they provide clarification on the treatment of work performed by various types of cooperative members in the International Classification of Status in Employment (ICSE-18), which divides workers into various categories of independent and dependent workers.

In particular, the Guidelines specify that worker-members are dependent workers: either employees or dependent contractors. This is because they do not have the same degree of control over the operation of their enterprise as, for example, a majority shareholder. They are dependent on decisions made by the management and/or the majority of members of the cooperative for aspects of their working conditions and the operation of the cooperative they jointly own.

If worker-members are paid a wage or salary for time worked or for each task or piece of work done in the cooperative, they should be classified as employees of their own cooperative. If they are paid only in profit or surplus, or paid a fee per service, they should be classified as dependent contractors. This is consistent with the classification by status in employment of dependent workers in other types of enterprise.

When work in the management and administration of a cooperative is performed by the owner-operators of enterprises that are members of producers' cooperatives, it should be considered for statistical purposes as a job as an employee of the cooperative if it is performed for pay. When these producer-members perform this type of work without pay, it should be considered as employment in their job in the member-enterprise. When this type of work is performed by worker-members of cooperatives, with or without additional pay, it should be considered as employment in their job in the cooperative.

If a consumer-member performs any type of work in their cooperative, including in management and administration, without pay, it should be treated as volunteer work. If a consumer-member performs work in the cooperative for pay, it would be as an employee.

It is also important to note that non-members can perform work in all types of cooperatives, including as employees, dependent contractors, unpaid trainee workers, and volunteer workers.

The economic contribution of cooperatives

To assess the economic contribution of cooperatives, the Guidelines note that different measures may be needed depending on the type of cooperative and that this would require information on:

- employment
- revenue
- value added
- assets
- liabilities
- the use of profits or surpluses
- investment
- the earnings of workers within the scope of statistics on cooperatives
- the share of transactions with members and non-members

Many but not all of these concepts are defined in existing international statistical standards, such as the System of National Accounts. However, the Guidelines do not provide advice on the relevance of each concept to the different types of cooperatives. There is currently little or no information in existing international statistical standards on how to measure concepts such as 'the use of profits or surplus' or 'the share of transactions with members and non-members', and the Guidelines state that the ILO, in collaboration with interested parties, should work on the development of measures to assess the economic contribution of cooperatives.

There are concerns about the limitations of conventional measures, such as value added, to measure the economic performance of cooperatives, given that their objectives are to benefit their members rather than to make profits for the cooperative (see for example, Uzea 2014). However, many of the positive economic effects frequently attributed to cooperatives are inherently difficult to measure. They include, for example, effects such as countervailing market power, pro-competitive effects, economic stability and resilience, and innovation. Measuring these effects may require the use of complex econometric methods, microsimulation, and modelling. There is a need for further methodological development work to specify the key variables that should be used as input to these types of analyses and that could potentially stand alone as indicators in their own right.

In addition to those listed above and other existing measures, the information required might include:

- value received
- value shared
- value of volunteer work
- patronage refunds
- share of intermediate consumption with members

For more information on the nature of the additional information needed, see Chapter 4: On the economic contribution of cooperatives in *Statistics on Cooperatives: Concepts, classification, work and economic contribution measurement* (Rousselière et al. 2020). To address these concerns, a Technical Working Group on Measuring the Economic Contribution of Cooperatives was established under the auspices of the Committee for the Promotion and Advancement of Cooperatives (COPAC). Its mandate is to develop a feasible set of statistical measures of the special economic contribution of cooperatives, based on both new and existing economic indicators.

Despite their limitations, the more conventional measures mentioned in the Guidelines (such as employment, revenue or turnover, value added, assets, and liabilities) are valid indicators that are relevant for assessment, even though incomplete, of the economic contribution of cooperatives.

Data collection, tabulation and analysis

Since there is a need for further development of data collection methods, the Guidelines do not provide detailed guidance on data collection. They do identify potential data sources and note that regular, preferably annual, monitoring of cooperatives can be based on administrative records if these are adapted for statistical purposes, as well as on establishment surveys. Additionally, data on persons who are members of cooperatives can be collected through household surveys. As previously discussed, household surveys are also an important potential source of statistics on work in cooperatives.

With respect to tabulation, the Guidelines specify the characteristics and breakdowns of cooperatives, members of cooperatives, and employment that should be included in statistical reports on cooperatives.

4. Putting the Guidelines into practice

Preparatory steps

Testing the data collection and measurement of the concepts and definitions presented in the Guidelines is an essential prerequisite for their effective implementation. The section of the Guidelines on future work states that the ILO should work together with interested countries and institutions to arrange for testing. Based on the experience and lessons learned from testing, the ILO plans to develop a manual providing practical guidance on the implementation of the Guidelines. However, before development and testing of new questions, or before new or modified surveys are conducted, a number of preparatory steps are essential.

An important first step in putting the Guidelines into practice at the national level is to identify the national requirements for statistics about cooperatives. It is essential to gain an understanding of national policy concerns related to cooperatives, of the strengths and limitations of the statistics and other information already available about cooperatives in the country, and of the challenges involved in collecting the information needed. Without this, it would be difficult to justify the commitment of skilled resources and funds to work on the development and field testing of questions. Equally, it would not be possible to determine whether the information obtained would be useful for the country.

While this is necessary for any statistical development work, it is particularly important in the case of cooperatives because of the wide variations in cooperative laws, administrative structures and types of cooperatives that exist in different countries. Consultation and dialogue between producers of statistics, including national statistical offices, and users of statistics and national experts on cooperatives are therefore essential. These users and experts should be drawn from government agencies responsible for cooperatives, cooperative confederations, academia, and government agencies responsible for employment and economic development. The identification of a group of experts and interested users from different national agencies could create a coalition of support at the national level for the development of statistics on cooperatives, and this might be facilitated by the formation of a working group or advisory group.

The preparatory work should include a review of national laws and administrative structures relevant to cooperatives, in order to develop a sound understanding of the landscape of cooperatives in the country. This will allow the identification of the agencies responsible for cooperatives and assist in the identification of relevant experts. It should also help to identify areas where the international Guidelines might need to be adapted to reflect national realities. For example, the operational definition of a cooperative could be aligned with and include terms based on national cooperative laws. The types of cooperatives recognized at the national level could be mapped to the typology provided in the Guidelines.

Before developing and testing new questions and methods, it is essential to identify existing data, survey questionnaires, databases, sample frames and other information and resources that could be relevant to compile the statistics specified in the Guidelines and to meet national needs. This will allow evaluation of the extent to which the required statistics can be compiled from existing data sources, identification of gaps in information, and identification and sharing of information about existing good practices. Modifications to existing data collections, such as adding new variables or modifying existing ones, can then be proposed to improve alignment of the statistics with the Guidelines and national user needs. Once data gaps and required modifications are identified, it

is critical to design the desired statistical outputs to be produced, and the description of the data variables to be measured, before launching into question testing.

If statistics on cooperatives are found in multiple data sources, it would be important to compare, cross-check and, to the extent possible, validate the information, with a view to potentially identifying a preferred source for each type of information and reconciling inconsistencies in the definitions and methodologies used.

In many countries, the ideal outcome of work to put the Guidelines into practice would be that regular statistics of cooperatives derived from mainstream national data collections, such as those conducted by the national statistical office, are complemented by periodic special purpose collections such as cooperative censuses, as well as from administrative data sources. Such special purpose collections can provide in-depth information on topics specifically relevant to cooperatives that could not easily be justified in data collections covering all types of enterprises. In many countries, however, these special purpose collections, typically conducted by the cooperative movement, are the main or only source of statistics on cooperatives. These statistics are frequently not comparable with official statistics on the wider economy and society.

Developing a national action plan

This section discusses various issues that should be taken into consideration in developing an action plan to implement the Guidelines at the national level based on national experience.

Firstly, to gain institutional support for the development of national statistics of cooperatives, the relevance and importance of establishing a national advisory committee, working group and/or steering group cannot be overemphasized. Typically, a wide range of government and non-government agencies will have a stake or interest in cooperative statistics or will be involved in the production and use of existing cooperative statistics. If these agencies are to be committed to any eventual recommendations and action plan to improve statistics of cooperatives, they will need to be involved in and able to influence its development. The functions of such a group might be:

- to advise and support evaluation studies on the implementation of the Guidelines;
- to provide guidance on reports and recommendations;
- to assist in developing a national action plan and business case, to promote national awareness of the findings, recommendations and plan;
- to support or be involved directly in the implementation of the plan.

Involvement of the agency or agencies responsible for official statistics on the economy and the labour market will be essential. This will promote the identification and publication of official statistics on cooperatives in line with the Guidelines, based on data regularly collected by the national statistical agency. Even if cooperatives are not currently identifiable in the agency's regular statistical outputs, data pertaining to cooperatives will surely be included in these outputs.

There are wide variations in national circumstances with respect to institutional arrangements for cooperatives, currently available statistics and data sources, and the capacity of national agencies to collect and disseminate statistics on cooperatives. There can therefore be no single one-size-fits-all template for a national action plan to improve national statistics on cooperatives in harmony with the Guidelines, as each country will be starting from a different base. Previous experiences in implementing the Guidelines, however, allow for the identification of the elements that could be included in national action plans in many countries.

Any national action plan to improve statistics on cooperatives and implement the ILO Guidelines will depend on nationally specific factors, including:

- national policy concerns and statistical needs with respect to cooperatives and their role in promoting sustainable development, economic growth and social justice;
- the national situation with respect to cooperative statistics, and the existing and potential data sources;
- the national legislative framework and administrative arrangements regarding cooperatives.

The first or preliminary phase of work towards a national action plan should therefore be a thorough assessment and evaluation of the national situation. It should include the following activities:

1. Identify and engage key stakeholders:
   a. Identify relevant national stakeholders with an interest in statistics of cooperatives, including:
      - government agencies responsible for cooperatives;
      - cooperative federations and confederations;
      - research institutions with an interest in cooperatives;
      - agencies responsible for national economic, social and environmental statistics.
   b. Establish an advisory committee or working group, and/or a steering committee made up of representatives of some or all of these agencies.
2. Assess the national situation, landscape and requirements for statistics of cooperatives including:
   a. identify national laws and administrative structures relevant to cooperatives;
   b. identify the types and subtypes of cooperatives legally recognized in the country;
   c. national policy concerns and requirements for statistics about cooperatives.
3. Identify the broad statistical outputs needed to implement the Guidelines in the country and to meet national policy needs.
4. Identify existing data, survey questionnaires, databases, sample frames and other information and resources that may be relevant to compile the statistics needed.
5. Evaluate the existing data and resources, describing strengths and limitations, and identifying gaps and needs for improvement in both national data and the Guidelines themselves.
6. Identify potential new sources of data and modifications to existing data collections needed to fully implement the Guidelines.
7. Make recommendations and proposals on methods to collect data from administrative and statistical registrations, censuses, and surveys, including designing and testing new questions, modifications to existing data collection forms, databases, registers, surveys and statistical outputs.
8. Make recommendations on national policies, a national action plan, and the business case to implement the Guidelines and better meet national requirements for statistics on cooperatives.

Those conducting assessments and evaluations of the national situation with respect to statistics of cooperatives may find it useful to make use of or adapt the two checklists that were used during the ILO pilot study in five countries. Checklist 1, “Identification of national requirements and landscape for statistics of cooperatives” is relevant for activities 1-3 listed above. Checklist 2, “Evaluation of existing and potential sources of information on cooperatives” is relevant for activities 4-5. These checklists are attached as Annex 1 and 2 respectively.

Once this preliminary phase of work has been completed, it will be possible to develop and agree on a national action plan and present the business case for it. The elements that may be included in the national plan, depending on national needs and circumstances, may include but would not be limited to the following:

- Establish formal partnership agreements among key stakeholders interested in statistics on cooperatives.
- Develop a communication plan tailored to the cooperative sector, emphasizing the importance of updated and reliable cooperative statistics and the variables that should be collected.
- Develop a communication strategy for the results of the Cooperative Census and statistics of cooperatives from other sources.
- Reconstruct the cooperative census including its questionnaire, list of variables and statistical outputs to incorporate the new variables needed to fully meet national needs in harmony with the ILO Guidelines.
- Include separate identification variables for cooperative types and subtypes in line with the Guidelines in statistical and administrative business registers, and match and harmonize these registers with cooperative registers held by relevant ministries and cooperative organizations.
- Include enterprise groups in the units model for business statistics to allow the identification of non-cooperative enterprises that are majority-owned by cooperatives.
- Add questions to regular and special purpose household surveys and business surveys, and to economic censuses, to allow measurement of the variables specified in the Guidelines, such as cooperative memberships, and work performed in cooperatives.
- Pilot test any reconstructed questionnaires and new survey questions and evaluate the usefulness of the resulting data.
- Compile and publish statistical outputs and reports within the scope of cooperative statistics based on data drawn from data collections in which cooperatives, work in cooperatives, members and membership can be identified.
- Publish key economic, social and environmental indicators in a manner that allows comparison of the contribution of cooperatives with that of other types of enterprises.
- Evaluate the results of the activities included in the plan and assess the final information gap between statistical production and Guidelines, to provide feedback to improve future collection and compilation of cooperative statistics.

Objectives of testing

Whenever questions or methods for the measurement of new concepts are added to data collection instruments (such as survey questionnaires and administrative forms), adequate testing is essential to ensure that they effectively capture the information required. This is also the case when entirely new data collection instruments are developed. Those providing the information should be able to understand what is being requested and be able to provide that information accurately, without excessive respondent burden. Several of the elements that may be included in a national action plan are likely to require such testing.

The main objectives of testing should be to develop methods for collecting the data required to measure:

- the number and types of cooperatives
- members and membership of cooperatives
- work in cooperatives
- the economic contribution of cooperatives

While there is not yet full agreement on relevant methodologies to comprehensively measure the economic contribution of cooperatives, many relevant data elements are likely to be available in existing data sources, provided that cooperatives can be identified in these data sources. However, additional information will be needed to provide a full assessment of the wealth and economic benefits created by cooperatives and this would require further testing. To fully put the Guidelines into practice, it is therefore necessary to reach international consensus on proposed variables to measure the economic contribution of cooperatives that are not currently included in mainstream economic statistics, as discussed above, and then to test them. These efforts should proceed in parallel with work on testing and development of the other elements, including methods to identify cooperatives in existing sources of mainstream economic statistics.

Identifying cooperatives in statistical data sources

The key requirement for the provision of statistics about cooperatives in line with the ILO Guidelines is to be able to identify enterprises in relevant data sources. The most suitable data sources for the identification of cooperatives are the registers of businesses, such as the commercial registers held by government agencies, registers of cooperatives held by apex organizations or governmental institutions responsible for cooperatives, and the statistical business registers held by national statistical offices. The critical issues for the compilation of statistics on cooperatives based on the information held in these registers are (1) that there is a data element in the register that allows cooperatives to be identified separately from other types of enterprises, and (2) that this identification is compliant with the four criteria for the operational measurement of cooperatives specified in the Guidelines and summarized as follows:

1. formal establishment as an institutional unit
2. democratic control
3. voluntary and non-restrictive membership
4. distribution of surpluses not linked to capital contributions

However, official government registers of businesses frequently do not identify cooperatives separately from other types of enterprises. Therefore, although cooperatives are registered as businesses, in many countries they are not necessarily registered specifically as cooperatives. Registers of cooperatives held by cooperative confederations or national government agencies responsible for cooperatives may be incomplete unless registration with these agencies is compulsory. These registers may also include records pertaining to inactive or defunct cooperatives. To ensure correct and comprehensive identification of cooperatives at the national level, it would therefore be necessary to develop and test methods to distinguish them from other types of enterprises in administrative and statistical registers of businesses – and in the censuses and surveys used to update and maintain these registers.

When cooperatives are identifiable in statistical business registers, it allows the wide range of data variables included in economic surveys and censuses to be used for the compilation of statistics on cooperatives. To achieve this, negotiation, agreement and close collaboration between statistical agencies and the agencies responsible for maintaining administrative registers would generally be needed. The methods used should aim to assess the extent to which an enterprise fulfils each of the four criteria in the operational definition of cooperatives provided in the Guidelines.

The purpose of specifying the four criteria for the operational measurement of cooperatives is to provide the basis to develop relatively simple operational methods to distinguish cooperatives from some other types of enterprise in data collections. However, experience in implementing the Guidelines suggests that, in some cases, these four operational criteria might not be sufficient to easily distinguish cooperatives from some other types of organizations. For example, testing in some countries has shown that an organization could meet these criteria, but not be defined as a cooperative under national laws that are consistent with the legal definition in ILO Recommendation No. 193, or with the International Cooperative Alliance's Statement of the Cooperative Identity. Similarly, some genuine cooperatives might be excluded if the criteria are interpreted too narrowly.

The concerns about the operational definition of cooperatives can be summarized as follows:

1. The definition as described by the criteria is too broad, meaning that some types of associations and other legal entities not considered to be cooperatives could be included.

2. The definition is too narrow and could exclude some legal entities registered as cooperatives in compliance with national legislation and aligned with the ICA definition of a cooperative and the seven cooperative principles.

3. While the ILO definition provides a solid foundation, it may not explicitly emphasize the 'mutual aim' that characterizes cooperatives. In developing national methods to identify cooperatives it would be important, therefore, to bear in mind that members of cooperatives have a mutual relationship with the cooperative in the sense that they are both owners of the cooperative and users of goods and services provided by cooperatives. A potential empirical indicator of this is the economic participation of members of the cooperative, as specified in principle 3 of the International Cooperative Alliance's Statement of Cooperative Identity.

There are also concerns that the four operational criteria do not refer to a characteristic that defines cooperatives in some national contexts, namely being a market producer that carries out commercial activities (as defined by the System of National Accounts). However, if this were strictly applied as a criterion to determine whether an institution is a cooperative, it could result in the exclusion of some social and non-profit cooperatives whose products and services are priced at significantly less than market value.

▶ Statement of the cooperative Identity (ICA 2017)

Definition of a cooperative:

A cooperative is an autonomous association of persons united voluntarily to meet their common economic, social, and cultural needs and aspirations through a jointly-owned and democratically-controlled enterprise.

Cooperative values:

Cooperatives are based on the values of self-help, self-responsibility, democracy, equality, equity and solidarity. In the tradition of their founders, cooperative members believe in the ethical values of honesty, openness, social responsibility and caring for others.

Cooperative principles:

The cooperative principles are guidelines by which cooperatives put their values into practice.

1. Voluntary and open membership

Cooperatives are voluntary organisations, open to all persons able to use their services and willing to accept the responsibilities of membership, without gender, social, racial, political or religious discrimination.

2. Democratic member control

Cooperatives are democratic organisations controlled by their members, who actively participate in setting their policies and making decisions. Men and women serving as elected representatives are accountable to the membership. In primary cooperatives members have equal voting rights (one member, one vote) and cooperatives at other levels are also organised in a democratic manner.

3. Member economic participation

Members contribute equitably to, and democratically control, the capital of their cooperative. At least part of that capital is usually the common property of the cooperative. Members usually receive limited compensation, if any, on capital subscribed as a condition of membership. Members allocate surpluses for any or all of the following purposes: developing their cooperative, possibly by setting up reserves, part of which at least would be indivisible; benefiting members in proportion to their transactions with the cooperative; and supporting other activities approved by the membership.

4. Autonomy and independence

Cooperatives are autonomous, self-help organisations controlled by their members. If they enter into agreements with other organisations, including governments, or raise capital from external sources, they do so on terms that ensure democratic control by their members and maintain their cooperative autonomy.

5. Education, training and information

Cooperatives provide education and training for their members, elected representatives, managers, and employees so they can contribute effectively to the development of their cooperatives. They inform the general public - particularly young people and opinion leaders - about the nature and benefits of cooperation.

6. Cooperation among cooperatives

Cooperatives serve their members most effectively and strengthen the cooperative movement by working together through local, national, regional and international structures.

7. Concern for community

Cooperatives work for the sustainable development of their communities through policies approved by their members.

Cases where the operational criteria may be too broad

The concerns about the criteria being too broad are primarily related to the fourth criterion, on the distribution of profits. This criterion does not (and should not) specify that profits and surpluses must be distributed to members, as this would exclude certain types of social cooperatives. Nor does any of the criteria specify that members must contribute capital as a condition of membership. Some institutions such as mutual societies, workers associations and other non-profit institutions would therefore meet the other three criteria and would not be excluded by the fourth criterion if they do not distribute profits and surpluses to members, even though they would not be considered to be cooperatives and do not adhere to the ICA's seven cooperative principles.

Similarly, these criteria do not exclude some institutions that are formally established by natural and legal persons, democratically controlled, have voluntary and non-restrictive membership, but do not function as cooperatives as specified in the ICA's Statement of Cooperative Identity or distribute profits or surplus among members. In this context, it is important to bear in mind that the purpose of a cooperative is not primarily to make a profit, but rather to serve the interests of its members. Any surplus may be distributed among members in a manner that is linked to the members' usage of its goods and/or services. Alternatively, surpluses may be invested into the cooperative with the aim of improving the goods or services it provides.

Cases where the ILO operational criteria may be too narrow

There are concerns that the ILO definition may be too narrow because strict interpretation of the criteria might exclude some enterprises that fall within the national definition of cooperatives, even though the legal framework for cooperatives in the country is broadly consistent with both the ILO operational definition and the ICA cooperative values and principles.

For example, the fourth criterion specified in the ILO Guidelines asserts that distribution of profits or surpluses among the members should not be directly linked to the capital contributed by each member (para. 19, iv). Therefore, if a cooperative raises capital by allowing members to purchase additional shares beyond what is required as a condition of membership, and dividends are distributed according to the number of shares held by members, it would be excluded from being counted as a cooperative. This would not, however, be consistent with the ICA's cooperative principles and associated guidance notes which state that cooperatives may invite members to make further voluntary capital investments which do not carry voting rights. If capital is invested voluntarily, it may be appropriate to pay interest on such investments at a "fair rate" or "compensatory rate" defined as "the lowest rate which would be sufficient to obtain the necessary funds" (ICA 2017). Indeed, if the issuance of such shares in addition to the contribution of capital required *as a condition of membership* does not give additional voting rights to members, it would reinforce the idea that the institution is a cooperative. If, on the other hand, the purchase of such shares does confer additional voting rights, the institution should not be considered as a cooperative.

It follows from this that Para 19 (iv) of the Guidelines should be interpreted as follows:

> distribution of profits or surpluses among the members should not be directly linked to the capital contributed by each member as a condition of membership. The issuance to members of any additional shares should not give additional voting rights, while the potential for remuneration in the form of dividends according to the number of additional shares held by individual members should be within defined limits, such as a maximum portion of profits or surpluses or a limited maximum profit rate.[3]

3 For a comprehensive discussion of issues around capital raising for cooperatives see Tan Suee Chieh and Chuin Ting Weber (Eds.), in *The Capital Conundrum for Co-operatives*.

Application of the operational criteria for identification of cooperatives

In summary, in applying the four criteria in the Guidelines to determine which institutional units are cooperatives, it is important to bear in mind that one of the primary distinguishing characteristics of cooperatives is that they are member-based with the objective of meeting the members' needs and interests. In developing methods to apply the four operational criteria for the identification of cooperatives, it would be important to assess whether strict interpretation of these criteria results in the exclusion of institutions widely considered to be cooperatives, or to the inclusion of institutions that are not considered to be cooperatives in the national context. The following points may be of assistance in making this assessment:

- Distribution of profits or surpluses among the members is allowed although it cannot be directly linked to the capital contributed by each member as a condition of membership.
- Distribution of profits may also be waived in the cooperative articles of association. In such cases the cooperative is also considered a non-profit institution.
- Cooperatives that are non-profit institutions differ from other non-profit institutions in that members are the users of goods and services provided by cooperatives and each member contributes to the capital of the cooperative.

In some cases, it may also be useful to assess whether the institutional types concerned meet the definition, values and principles specified in the ICA Statement of the Cooperative Identity shown above.

Bearing all these considerations in mind, two broad approaches might be envisaged for the identification of cooperatives in data sources to be used for the compilation of statistics:

1. identification in administrative and statistical registers held by cooperative confederations or by government agencies responsible for cooperatives, for the registration of businesses or for the compilation of statistics;
2. inclusion of questions to distinguish cooperatives from other types of enterprise in surveys of businesses.

Using business registers to identify cooperatives

In many countries it may not be necessary to apply the four operational criteria for the identification of cooperatives to each and every institutional unit in a statistical collection. If the national requirements for registration as a cooperative are consistent with the operational definition in the Guidelines and with the ICA cooperative principles, then all enterprises registered as cooperatives could be counted as cooperatives for statistical purposes.

As noted above, information about cooperatives may be held in registers of businesses compiled by different national agencies for a variety of purposes:

- Registers of cooperatives are held by apex organizations or governmental institutions responsible for the administration of cooperatives.
- Commercial registers are held by government agencies responsible for the administration and/or taxation of businesses.
- Statistical business registers are held by national statistical offices for the purpose of compiling statistics.[4]

4 For a more detailed discussion of the strengths and weaknesses of the different data sources identifying the SSE population, including cooperatives), see Chapter 3 of Bouchard and Salathé-Beaulieu (2021).

If the original identification of cooperatives is based on registers of businesses held by cooperative confederations or national government agencies responsible for cooperatives, it would be reasonable to assume that checks were undertaken to verify that the enterprises included meet either national criteria to be registered as cooperatives, or the criteria required for membership of the confederation. However, it would nevertheless be advisable to understand the verification methods used, before assuming that all enterprises identified as cooperatives in a given register should be defined as cooperatives for official statistical purposes.

Administrative registers of cooperatives or of all types of businesses can be used directly to identify the population to be included in a survey or census of cooperatives. Unless registration as a cooperative is compulsory, however, it is possible that significant numbers of enterprises that function as cooperatives may not be listed as such in these registers. There may also be multiple registers held by federations representing cooperatives in different industries or regions, and these registers may have differing contents and data structures. Some cooperatives may be listed in registers held by more than one federation.

> There have been concerns that businesses may register as cooperatives to benefit from favourable taxation or other administrative provisions, without necessarily adhering to the ICA's cooperative values and principles. The appropriate treatment of such enterprises in official statistics of cooperatives might depend on national circumstances, information needs and the extent of the problem.

In some countries, cooperatives are already identified as an institutional form in the business registers used by national statistical agencies. Statistical business registers are typically kept up to date by drawing data from various registers used for administrative purposes, as well as from surveys conducted by the national statistical office. These registers typically include basic data about each business included in the register and also provide a sampling frame for the conduct of various surveys of enterprises. Identification of cooperatives in a statistical business register means that the wealth of information about cooperatives already held in the databases of national statistical offices, but frequently not identifiable, can be put to effective use to compile statistics on cooperatives on the same basis as statistics on the economy as a whole. For many countries, separate identification of cooperatives on statistical business registers could be the most important step towards facilitating the compilation of regular statistics on cooperatives.

In Italy, for example, cooperatives are identified as an institutional form in the national statistical office's system of statistical business registers, as well as in the commercial registers used for administrative purposes. This allows a wide range of statistics about cooperatives collected in surveys, censuses and administrative data sources to be compiled in a manner that facilitates comparison with other types of enterprise.

In the United Republic of Tanzania, the 2023/24 Tanzania Statistical Business Register Report reported the results of the first complete enumeration (a census) of all operating economic units with a fixed location in the country. It includes statistics on type of ownership, which show that 1.5 per cent of all establishments are cooperatives, with much higher percentages in some industries.

Identifying types of cooperatives

Once a cooperative is identified, it will also be necessary to use information about the nature and interests of its members to determine the type of cooperative:

- producer
- worker
- consumer/user
- multi-stakeholder

The definitions of each of these types are discussed in Chapter 3 above.

Methods to determine the type of cooperative should be another stream of development work on implementing the Guidelines at the national level. Two broad approaches to classifying cooperatives according to the four ILO types can be envisaged:

- mapping directly from national categories of cooperatives, typically used for administrative purposes, to one of the four types specified in the ILO Guidelines;
- collecting additional information to determine the most appropriate ILO type.

In some cases, a combination of these approaches may be appropriate.

Mapping directly from national categories to ILO types

In many countries it is possible to map some or all the existing national categories of cooperatives directly to one of the four types of cooperatives specified in the ILO Guidelines. When there is a direct correspondence between categories in the national typology and a single type specified in the Guidelines, this can be represented in a correspondence table which can be used to facilitate the compilation of statistics according to the types in the Guidelines.

Various approaches to mapping national categories to the four ILO types can be envisaged. In Türkiye, for example, the relevant sections of the sample articles of association of each national sub-type were assessed to map the large number of national categories of cooperatives onto the four broad categories in the ILO Guidelines. Focussing on the purpose, objectives, and membership conditions of cooperatives, it was found that almost all the types of cooperatives defined in Türkiye could be matched exactly with the broad categories defined in the ILO Guidelines. The exception was education cooperatives. While this was a quick and relatively easy method, there were concerns about potential mismatches, as the mapping process involved the risk of overgeneralization. It is proposed, therefore, to complement the mapping study in Türkiye with a targeted survey to test whether mapping based only on the articles of association is sufficient.

In Italy, the mapping of the national classification of cooperatives used in the Ministry of Enterprises and Made in Italy (MIMIT) register of cooperatives is more complex, as shown below in table 2. Correspondence between the categories of cooperatives in the ILO Guidelines and those in the Italian national classification is possible, but with some limitations due to the inability to unequivocally assign certain national types of cooperatives to a single ILO category. In particular, multi-stakeholder cooperatives are difficult to identify through administrative data provided on the register. One potential solution to this type of problem would be to adjust the classification of cooperatives in the administrative register, but there may be limitations to what is possible in a register whose primary purpose is administrative. An alternative strategy in this type of situation would be to modify the questionnaires used to collect data on cooperatives such that the categories specified in the ILO Guidelines can be identified, as we discuss in more detail below.

▶ Table 2. Analysis of cooperative types used by the Ministry of Enterprises and Made in Italy (MIMIT)

MIMIT type	Active coops %[5]	Members	Activity	User-relationships	ILO types
Production and worker cooperative	43.8	Workers	Industry and services	The members are workers of the cooperative	Worker
Agricultural labour cooperative	3.7	Workers	Agriculture and livestock	The members are workers of the cooperative	Worker
Social cooperative	26.1	Workers, users, volunteers, donors	Social and health care (type A); any kind of activity aimed at integrating disadvantaged people into work (type B)	The same members may be both workers, volunteers, donors, or supporters of the cooperative and consumers of its services	Worker Multistakeholder
Agricultural and livestock cooperative	6.7	Producers	Provision of farm supplies (retail) and food processing of farm products (manufacturing)	Producers of the cooperative's inputs	Producer
Housing cooperative	3.7	Users	Housing services	Users of the housing provided by the cooperative	Consumer/user
Fishing cooperative	1.7	Producers, workers, or users	Fishing and aquaculture	Work is carried out by members in favour of the cooperative, or in the provision of services (related to the fishing activity) by fisher members. Alternatively, the cooperative processes, and sells the catch provided by members	Producer Worker
Consumer cooperative	1.6	Users	Wholesale and trade	Users of the goods sold by the cooperative	Consumer/user
Retailers' cooperative	0.2	Producers	Wholesale and trade	Owners of the shops	Producer
Transport cooperative	1.9	Workers or users	Transport	The same members may be both workers and users of the cooperative's services	Producer Worker
Cooperative consortium	0.2	Producers and/or users (cooperatives)	Agriculture, services	Members are cooperatives using the services of the consortium	Producer[6]
Agricultural consortium	0.1	Producers and/or users (farms)	Agriculture sector	Consumers of farm supplies through the cooperative	Producer
Cooperative bank	0.5	Users	Banking sector	Users of the services of the bank	Consumer/user

5 Obtained by cross-referencing the ASIA Business Register and MIMIT cooperative register (2020).

6 The version of this table appearing in the Italian national report of the pilot study, published in ILO 2024, indicates that it was impossible to verify without additional information whether the MIMIT types Cooperative consortium and Agricultural consortium should be mapped to ILO types Producer or User. It has subsequently been determined that cooperative consortia and other apex cooperatives should generally be classified as Producer cooperatives as their function is primarily to provide products and services to their members.

MIMIT type	Active coops %[5]	Members	Activity	User-relationships	ILO types
Guarantee and credit consortia and cooperatives	0.4	Users. Not physical persons but trade associations	Providing guarantees to the banking system to facilitate obtaining short-, medium-, and long-term financing for economic and production activities.	Users benefit from guarantees to the banking system to facilitate obtaining short-, medium-, and long-term financing for economic and production activities	Consumer/user
Other cooperatives	9.1	Difficult to define	Across all the sectors	Hard to define because there is no information about members	Some multistakeholder coops are listed in this category. There is insufficient information to identify them

Source: ILO 2024

Collecting additional information to determine the most appropriate ILO type

When it is not possible to map directly from national types to a single type specified in the ILO Guidelines, compilation of data according to these types would require collection of information on the nature of the members' interest in the cooperatives. This may be necessary for all categories of cooperatives, or only for the categories that cannot reliably be mapped to the four ILO categories. This information would need to be collected in the original data sources, such as a cooperative census or application forms to register a business as a cooperative.

While business registers and establishment censuses covering the whole economy could potentially collect the detailed information required to identify the types of cooperatives, it may be difficult to justify collecting this type of information in data collections covering all types of enterprises. Establishment surveys could potentially collect this type of information, but samples may not always be large enough to allow compilation of reliable statistics on the distribution of cooperatives by type. Once a cooperative has been assigned definitively to one of the four ILO types, it would be appropriate to store this information in relevant administrative and statistical business registers.

In Costa Rica, for example, the cooperative census has previously used a typology of cooperatives based on the management structure of the cooperative, plus two additional categories for cooperatives in schools and colleges. This typology cannot feasibly be mapped to the four types specified in the ILO Guidelines. It is proposed that the existing typology should be maintained while collecting additional information in the cooperative census to allow cooperatives to be allocated to the four types specified in the ILO Guidelines. The four categories specified in the Guidelines were considered useful for national purposes, while also facilitating the provision of cumulative and comparative information across countries.

Identifying subsidiaries of cooperatives

According to the Guidelines, a full assessment of the economic and employment impact of cooperatives requires the identification not only of cooperatives, but also of subsidiaries of cooperatives.[7] This is an important issue, as many cooperatives do not distinguish the information

7 Corporation B is said to be a subsidiary of corporation A when: a. Either corporation A controls more than half of the shareholders' voting power in corporation B; or b. Corporation A is a shareholder in corporation B with the right to appoint or remove a majority of the directors of corporation B (SNA 2008,70, §4.73).

relating to the parent establishment from information concerning their subsidiaries, hence inflating the numbers about cooperatives considerably. At the same time, excluding information about subsidiaries of cooperatives would result in an underestimation of the full economic impact of the cooperative movement and its contribution to employment. This implies the need for the compilation of separate statistics for cooperatives and for their subsidiaries that are not themselves cooperatives.

Identification of subsidiaries of cooperatives in administrative registers may be possible, as these registers may contain information about the ownership structure of corporations. For example, in 2015, the Italian National Institute of Statistics (Istat) published a brief statistical note on enterprise groups with details of groups by the legal form of the parent company, including cooperatives (Istat 2015). Although the note was not subsequently updated, statistics on cooperative-controlled enterprises and cooperative groups could be obtained by processing data contained in Istat's business register system,[8] which provides control links between enterprises at both the national and multinational levels, as well as some basic characteristics of the group to which they belong.

Alternatively, additional questions about ownership structure could be added to forms used for the registration of businesses, or to establishment censuses and surveys. It would be necessary, however, to assess the extent to which this is feasible and include a data element in the register to indicate whether an enterprise is a subsidiary of a cooperative.

A part of the work to put the Guidelines into practice, therefore, would be to develop and test questions and methods to identify subsidiaries of cooperatives. However, this might have a lower priority than the measurement of numbers and types of cooperatives.

Measuring members and memberships of cooperatives

The Guidelines note that statistics on persons who are members of cooperatives, including owner-operators of enterprises that are members of cooperatives, should be systematically disaggregated by significant characteristics of the person, in particular by sex, age group, geographical region and urban and rural area, and by type of member.

Administrative registers of cooperatives will frequently include information on the number of memberships of cooperatives, broken down according to the types of cooperatives used nationally. However, this information may not be up-to-date and is likely to contain limited information about the demographic and other characteristics of the members. In addition, data on the number of memberships of cooperatives cannot be used to accurately measure the number of people or enterprises that are members of at least one cooperative. Various methods could be envisaged to compile up-to-date information about members and memberships:

- data on the number and characteristics of members could be added to administrative audits of cooperatives, if conducted on a regular basis;
- more detailed information on memberships and the characteristics of members could be collected in censuses of cooperatives;
- questions on membership of cooperatives could be included in household surveys and establishment surveys.

Slightly different approaches may be needed to collect information for producer-members compared to worker and consumer members. This is because relevant information about enterprises and persons may best be obtained from different types of data sources.

8 Following the European Regulation No. 177/2008.

Measuring producer-members of cooperatives

In theory, information about whether a business is a member of a cooperative could be held in administrative registers. Collecting this type of information and keeping it up to date could be challenging and burdensome for official administrative registers, however. Moreover, in countries with a significant informal sector, small enterprises (such as farms and handicraft manufacturers) that are members of producers' cooperatives may not all be formally registered as businesses with government authorities. These enterprises, or the persons who own them, may therefore be included on a cooperative register, but not on government registers of businesses.

Cooperatives themselves do maintain registers of their members. In principle, this information could be used to identify enterprises that are members of cooperatives on statistical business registers and in survey data. However, collecting information from individual cooperatives about their members and matching it with information about enterprises in statistical registers or survey data would be a complex and challenging exercise, and is not recommended. Information about enterprises that are members of cooperatives should therefore be collected in the same data source as information about their economic and employment characteristics. This would require one or more questions about membership of cooperatives in enterprise surveys and censuses. There is a need therefore to develop and test methods and questions to identify enterprises that are producer-members of cooperatives.

It may also be possible to identify producer-members of cooperatives in household surveys, such as labour force surveys, or in informal sector surveys, by asking workers in employment for profit a question on whether they (or their enterprises) are members of a producer cooperative. Workers employed for profit are generally identified through questions on status in employment and include owner-operators of enterprises (employers and own-account workers), as well as dependent contractors and contributing family workers. Thorough testing would be essential, as the respondent in a household survey may not understand the distinction between producer cooperatives and other types of cooperatives. However, this approach could allow the identification of small and informal sector producer-members that might not be included in formal sector establishment surveys. It could also allow the compilation of statistics about the characteristics of the people who own and operate these enterprises. Since labour force surveys generally collect information on the number of workers in the establishment (albeit in ranges), it could be possible to use these surveys to estimate total employment in enterprises that are producer-members.

Measuring worker-members and consumer-members of cooperatives

To identify people who are members of cooperatives, the cooperatives themselves can provide information on the number of worker-members or consumer-members of the cooperative. They can also provide limited information such as age and sex about their characteristics as people. This would allow calculation of the number of memberships. The most suitable source of information on memberships and the basic characteristics of members would be a census of cooperatives. An establishment survey could also potentially collect this information.

Cooperatives cannot provide information about the number of people or households that are members of at least one cooperative, since some are members of more than one cooperative. Comprehensive measurement of people who are members of cooperatives would require development and testing of questions on membership in household surveys. In a small number of countries, household surveys have been used to identify whether individuals and their families or households are members of cooperatives or mutual societies. For example, in the National Household Survey in Costa Rica, information about membership of cooperatives is collected as part of a question on membership of community organizations (INEC Costa Rica 2021).

Generalizing this approach for use in other countries would require careful testing, as survey respondents may not know whether they or other members of their household are members of cooperatives. For example, individuals may assume that a retail trade chain is a cooperative because they have a subscription to be offered discounts. Alternatively, they may not be aware or have forgotten that a small sum they paid into savings and loan institution was a member share of a cooperative.

In the Republic of Korea, the cooperative database includes information on the number of members by type, namely producer, consumer, and worker members, as of the date of the initial registration of the establishment. However, it does not provide information on the current number of members or on their demographic characteristics, such as sex and age. To address this concern, a question module on membership and employment in cooperatives has been proposed for use in household surveys. This could potentially be used as a model for testing in other countries.

Question on membership of community organizations, Costa Rica National Household Survey

H6. Is (name) an active member of any of the following organizations...

	Yes	No
...a cooperative?	☐	☐
...a trade union?	☐	☐
...a solidarity association?	☐	☐
...a trade association (including professional associations)?	☐	☐
... a community association?	☐	☐
... other (specify)	☐	☐

Proposed question module on membership of and employment in cooperatives in the Republic of Korea

1. Are you a member of any of the following cooperatives (check all that apply)?

- ▶ If not, have you ever been a member of any of the following cooperatives (check all that apply)?

2. Do you work for any of the following cooperatives for earnings (check all that apply)?

- ▶ If not, have you ever worked for any of the following cooperatives for earnings (check all that apply)?

Measuring work in cooperatives

Cooperatives and their subsidiaries could generally be expected to provide basic information about the number of employees working for them during a particular reference period, including the number of worker-members. They could potentially also provide information about the number and basic characteristics of volunteers or unpaid trainee workers. Statistics on the number of employees and hours worked are commonly collected in establishment surveys. These surveys could therefore provide information on total employment and hours worked in cooperatives, if cooperatives can be distinguished from other types of enterprises. A census of cooperatives would also be able to provide this type of information.

Household surveys provide more comprehensive information about people, their jobs, the number of jobs held by each person, the characteristics of their jobs such as status in employment and occupation, and their social, demographic and economic characteristics. However, household surveys rarely collect information about whether a person works in a cooperative, a subsidiary of a cooperative, or for an employer that is a producer-member of a cooperative.

A possible way of identifying employment in cooperatives in household surveys would be to add a response category, "a cooperative" to existing standard questions on the institutional sector of the employer. Such questions are almost always present in Labour Force Surveys, which in many countries are conducted at least annually.

Thorough testing would be essential to measure the effectiveness of the modified question, as well as the potential impact on responses to the other categories listed in the question. Other potential approaches could also be investigated.

An example asked of employees is included in the ILO model LFS questionnaire (ILO 2020, 7-MJJ_10) and could potentially be modified by adding a response category for cooperatives as follows:

In this job, (are/is) (you/he/she) working in....

READ

i) The government or a state-owned enterprise

ii) A cooperative

iii) A farm

iv) A private business (non-farm)

v) A household(s) as a domestic worker

vi) An NGO, non-profit institution, church

vii) An international organization or a foreign embassy

Measuring work in subsidiaries and producer-members of cooperatives

To fully measure work performed within the scope of statistics of cooperatives, and thus make a full assessment of the impact of cooperatives on employment, it is necessary to identify not only work performed in the cooperatives themselves but also in subsidiaries of cooperatives, and in enterprises that are producer-members of cooperatives. As noted above, producer-members of cooperatives may be members of producer cooperatives or multi-stakeholder cooperatives.

In household surveys, it would be difficult to identify employees and other dependent workers in these types of enterprises, as respondents would not necessarily know that their employer is a subsidiary of a cooperative or a member of a cooperative. It should be possible, however, to use establishment surveys and establishment censuses to provide estimates of the numbers and some other characteristics of employees in establishments that are subsidiaries or members of cooperatives – provided that the status of these establishments as members of a cooperative can be separately identified in the data source.

▶ Table 3. Potential for different data sources to provide statistics for selected key variables

	Number of cooper-atives	Number of cooper-atives by type	Number of mem-bers or mem-ber-ships by type of cooperative	Employees in cooperatives	Employees in cooperatives by type of cooperative	Other workers in cooperatives by type	Value added of cooperatives
Register of enterprises	yes	possibly	no	possibly	no	no	no
Census of enterprises	yes	possibly	no	possibly	no	no	no
Establishment survey (production)	yes	possibly	producer-members	possibly	no	no	yes
Establishment survey (employment and earnings)	yes	possibly	producer-members	possibly	possibly	possibly	no
Cooperative Census	yes	yes	member-ships	yes	yes	yes	yes
Household Survey	no	no	members	yes	yes	yes	no

Measuring the economic contribution of cooperatives

Significant further research and development work will be needed to develop comprehensive measures of the special economic effects of cooperatives. The Guidelines also list several conventional variables that are relevant for measuring the economic contribution of cooperatives, such as those specified in the System of National Accounts and other international statistical standards, including:

- employment
- revenue
- value added
- assets
- liabilities
- the use of profits or surpluses
- investment
- the earnings of workers

In many countries, statistics on these measures are available for all enterprises including cooperatives, as part of regularly disseminated official statistics compiled by national statistical offices. However, these indicators are rarely broken down to allow separate identification of cooperatives. It may be feasible, nevertheless, to compile and publish such key economic indicators in a manner that allows comparison of the contribution of cooperatives with that of other types of enterprise, provided that three conditions are met.

- Firstly, it should be possible to identify cooperatives separately from other types of enterprises in the original data source.
- Secondly, for data collected through sample surveys, the contribution of cooperatives to the estimates should be sufficient to allow the dissemination of statistics with acceptable levels of sampling error.
- Thirdly, the estimates released should not breach regulations and good practice regarding data confidentiality.[9]

The need for further development work to allow measurement of the special economic effects of cooperatives should not, however, be a reason to delay measurement and compilation of statistics on cooperatives based on conventional economic indicators, even though this would only partially measure their economic contribution. Such partial measurement of the economic contribution of cooperatives is already possible in some countries. It can be achieved either through separate identification of cooperatives in data sources used to compile economic statistics on all types of enterprises, or through the inclusion of relevant and standardized variables in data collections targeting cooperatives.

In publishing and interpreting statistics according to conventional economic indicators, it is important to provide information on their limitations and relevance with respect to cooperatives. For example, measurement of value-added may be underestimated or overestimated in cooperatives, since part of the intermediate consumption may be made to the benefit of producer-members, and most if not all the sales to the benefit of consumer-members (Rousselière et al. in Bouchard et al. 2020, pp 40-41.).

Measuring the social, cultural and environmental impacts of cooperatives

It has become apparent in testing and evaluating the Guidelines that there is a need for statistics not only on the economic contribution of cooperatives, but also on their, social, cultural and environmental impacts. The Guidelines provide little or no information on these issues beyond measures related to employment, earnings and memberships. Yet the cooperative ownership model, in putting the interests of members ahead of profits, could be assumed to confer significant social, cultural and environmental benefits. Measuring only the economic contribution of cooperatives may not, therefore, be sufficient to fully understand the broader contribution they may make towards the goals of decent work for all, social inclusion, the eradication of poverty and an environmentally stable economy.

To measure the social, cultural and environmental impacts of cooperatives, and to collect and compile relevant statistics, a specific conceptual and statistical framework would be needed. It is proposed to develop such a framework as part of the work to develop a comprehensive manual on statistics of cooperatives.

Pending completion of this work, countries wishing to compile statistics on the wider dimensions of the impact of cooperatives could consider identifying existing indicators that could feasibly and meaningfully be compiled or adapted to allow comparison of the impacts of cooperatives with other types of enterprise. Suitable indicators might be identified among existing frameworks developed for monitoring social, cultural, environmental, governance and sustainability concerns. Potentially relevant indicator frameworks include:

9 For example, if it is known that only two cooperatives contribute to a large majority of the estimates on revenue in a particular industry, each of these cooperatives will know the numbers it provided to the national statistical office. It may be possible, therefore, for one of these cooperatives to estimate the contribution made by the other, by subtracting its own contribution from the published total.

- Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) indicators;
- the ILO's *Decent Work Indicators*;
- the indicators specified in the United Nations Research Institute for Social Development (UNRISD) publication: *Authentic Sustainability Assessment: A User Manual for the Sustainable Development Performance Indicators*;
- the *Handbook for Measuring Quality of Employment, A Statistical Framework* (UNECE 2015) prepared by the Expert Group on Measuring Quality of Employment, established by the Bureau of the Conference of European Statisticians;
- various indicators and initiatives at national and regional levels such as those related to the development of satellite accounts for the social economy.

Summary of methodological work required to put the Guidelines into practice

In summary, the methodological work needed to implement the Guidelines at the national level will need to focus on the following objectives.

1. **Undertake preparatory work to identify the national requirements and landscape for statistics of cooperatives including:**

   a. national requirements for statistics about cooperatives;

   b. national laws and administrative structures relevant to cooperatives;

   c. government agencies responsible for cooperatives, cooperative federations, and research institutions with an interest in cooperatives;

   d. the types and subtypes of cooperative recognized in the country.

2. **Identify and assess existing data, survey questionnaires, databases, sample frames and other information and resources that could be relevant to compile the statistics specified in the Guidelines and to meet national needs for statistics on cooperatives. The investigation should cover data collection and compilation activities undertaken by:**

   a. national statistics offices;

   b. relevant research institutions;

   c. government agencies responsible for cooperatives;

   d. agencies responsible for promoting economic activities in sectors where cooperatives are known to be important, such as agriculture;

   e. registration of businesses;

   f. cooperative federations.

3. **Develop and test methods to collect data from businesses in administrative and statistical registers, censuses, and surveys to identify as the highest priority:**

   a. types of cooperatives: producer, worker, consumer/user, multi-stakeholder;

and as a lower priority:

b. subsidiaries of cooperatives;

c. enterprises that are producer-members of cooperatives.

4. Develop and test methods and questions to be used in household surveys to identify as a high priority:

a. employees in cooperatives, possibly using a response category for cooperatives added to existing questions on the institutional sector of the employer;

and as a lower priority:

b. producer-members of cooperatives as owner-operators of their own enterprise, possibly sequenced from questions on status in employment;

c. members and memberships of cooperatives in general by type of cooperative.

5. Develop and test methodologies to assess the economic performance of cooperatives and the extent to which data available in existing sources are adequate

Significant further conceptual and methodological work is needed at the international level to identify the variables required to fully measure the economic contribution of cooperatives. The suitability of existing data sources should nevertheless be assessed to compile statistics on cooperatives for the conventional indicators of economic performance proposed in the Guidelines. These include employment, revenue (turnover), value added, assets, liabilities and investment. This would first require the capacity to identify cooperatives in these existing sources, or modifications to the associated data collection instruments to allow the identification of cooperatives. Once cooperatives can be identified in these sources, testing should involve the compilation of estimates for cooperatives for each of these variables, and assessment of the reliability and usefulness of the resulting statistics.

While the Guidelines do not specify methods to measure the social, cultural and environmental impacts of cooperatives, there is a known demand for this type of information. Pending development of international guidance on these topics, countries may wish to identify existing indicators that could feasibly and meaningfully be compiled or adapted to allow comparison of the impacts of cooperatives with other types of enterprise.

Concluding remarks

The Guidelines describe the concepts, statistical units, definitions and classifications needed to collect and compile internationally comparable statistics on cooperatives and types of cooperatives, members of cooperatives and work in cooperatives. Significant research and methodological development work will be required to fully implement the Guidelines at the national level. Essential first steps will be to establish the national requirements for statistics on cooperatives at the national level, to understand the cooperative landscape in the country, to assess the currently available statistics and identify improvements and potential new sources of data needed to fully implement the Guidelines.

Rather than trying to implement all elements of the Guidelines at once, countries may need to follow an incremental or step-by-step approach, with a focus on the most important issues, on any aspects that can be implemented with relatively minimal effort, and on any opportunities that present themselves such as the planned revision of relevant data collections.

Depending on national circumstances, high priority in the early stages of implementation should be given to:

- identification of cooperatives in administrative and statistical business registers and in relevant economic censuses and surveys, which may allow assessment of the economic contribution of cooperatives, based on conventional measures such as value added, turnover and headcounts. Information about the limitations of these measures in relation to cooperatives, especially with respect to value added, should be provided with any statistical outputs;
- revision of existing or planned censuses and surveys of cooperatives conducted by government agencies responsible for cooperatives, cooperative confederations or other agencies, to improve alignment with the Guidelines and with official statistics on the whole economy;
- identification of employees in cooperatives in household surveys such as the LFS.

When progress has been made in one or all of these three areas, it may then be possible to undertake further methodological work to identify and measure lower priority or more complex elements needed to fully assess the economic and social impacts of cooperatives, including:

- members and memberships of cooperatives in general, and types of memberships;
- types of cooperatives;
- subsidiaries of cooperatives;
- work in subsidiaries of cooperatives and producer-members of cooperatives.

Particular attention may need to be given to the collection of data on subsidiaries of cooperatives, as many cooperatives do not separately identify information relating to the parent cooperative establishment from information pertaining to their non-cooperative subsidiaries.

In parallel, there is a need to agree at the international level on variables to measure the economic contribution of cooperatives that are not currently included in mainstream economic statistics and then to test them, and to develop methods to measure their social, cultural and environmental impacts. Pending completion of this work, countries may nevertheless wish to adapt relevant existing measures and indicators to identify cooperatives separately from other types of enterprise.

Based on experience in implementing the Guidelines in several countries, the ILO plans to develop a manual on the collection and compilation of statistics of cooperatives in accordance with the Guidelines.

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Annexes

Annex 1
Checklist 1: Identification of national requirements and landscape for statistics of cooperatives

The purpose of this checklist is to make an initial assessment and provide a framework to subsequently record more detailed information on:

- the governance, legislative and registration arrangements for cooperatives in the country;
- the requirements and demand for statistics about cooperatives;
- the currently available statistics on cooperatives;
- potential future sources of statistics on cooperatives.

Initially record all relevant information you are aware of or can easily find on the internet or other sources.

For some questions it will be necessary to conduct interviews with relevant informants, and/or undertake further background research. The checklist should be used to record more complete information and expand on the initial responses.

Add as much space as needed to record as complete information as possible

Government oversight and legal framework

1. Is there a Government agency or ministry with general responsibility for cooperatives?

If yes provide:

a. Name of agency or ministry:

b. Contact details:

Record the physical and postal address, email address and phone numbers of the agency in general, and the names, functions and contact details of relevant informants.

c. What are this agency's main functions with respect to cooperatives?

If there are several agencies, please repeat a, b and c.

2. Are there any (other) Government agencies or ministries that have a department, section or other organizational unit responsible for cooperatives within the agency's area of responsibility, for example for agriculture, housing, finance and so forth ...?

a. Name(s) and contact details of agency(ies) or ministry(ies):

For each agency, record the physical and postal address, email address and phone numbers of the agency in general, and the names, functions and contact details of relevant informants or departments.

b. For each of these agencies, provide details of its interests and functions in relation to cooperatives.

3. Is there a national legal definition that distinguishes cooperatives from other types of enterprise or institution?

If yes, please provide the details and the data and source of the definition. If the definition has changed over time, please provide the latest definition and details of any previous versions if this is relevant.

4. Do any of the agencies identified above have their own definitions or criteria for defining cooperatives?

If yes, please provide details.

5. If there is a national legal definition of cooperatives in general, how do these agency specific definitions differ from it?

Registration of enterprises and cooperatives

6. Which agency or agencies are responsible for the registration of enterprises for administrative and legal purposes?

Provide name of agency, link to website, and names and contact details of informants. If there is more than one type of registration, please provide all relevant details.

7. Is there a national register of companies, corporations, or enterprises?

- **a.** Provide all relevant details and links to any information available online.
- **b.** Does this register distinguish cooperatives from other types of enterprise? For example, is there a field or category in the company register that identifies whether an enterprise is a cooperative?
- **c.** If yes, what criteria or methods are used to determine that an enterprise is a cooperative?

If there is more than one register, please provide these details for all registers.

8. Are there any separate Government registers of cooperatives (including final consumer cooperatives such as housing cooperatives, other types of cooperatives or regional registers)?

The organizations listed in these registers may or may not also be listed on the main national commercial or company register. For example, in the United Kingdom cooperatives are registered by the Financial Conduct Authority in the Mutuals Public Register which is linked electronically to the general companies register maintained by Companies House.

If there are separate registers for different economic activities or types of activities, provide information for all registers.

For each register, record the following details and links to any relevant information available online.

- **a.** Name, postal address, and website
- **b.** Does the register distinguish cooperatives from other types of organization? For example, is there a field or category in the register that identifies whether an organization is a cooperative?
- **c.** If yes, what criteria or methods are used to determine that an organization is a cooperative?
- **d.** Does the register include all cooperatives registered in the country, region or economic sector?

Cooperative confederations

9. Is there a national confederation of cooperatives covering all areas of economic activity?

Record the following details and links to any relevant information available online:

- **a.** Name, postal address, and website

b. What criteria or methods are used by the confederation to determine that an enterprise is a cooperative?

c. What information about cooperatives and their memberships can be found in the confederation's register of members?

d. What proportion of cooperatives are members of the confederation?

10. Are there any regional confederations of cooperatives or sectoral confederations covering only certain areas of economic activity, for example associations of agricultural or housing cooperatives?

Record the following details and links to any relevant information available online:

a. Name, postal address and website

b. What criteria or methods are used by the confederation to determine that an enterprise is a cooperative?

c. What information about cooperatives and their memberships can be found in the confederation's register of members?
What proportion of cooperatives within scope of the confederation's area of activity are members?

Types of cooperatives

11. What types and subtypes of cooperatives are recognized in the country by Government agencies and cooperative federations?

Please list all types or subtypes identified, the agencies using the types, and any information available concerning how they are differentiated.

Academic and research institutions

12. Are there any research institutes, universities, or other academic institutions with an interest in cooperatives, or that have published reports on the economic, social or employment impact of cooperatives?

Record the physical and postal address, email address and phone numbers of each institution, and the names, functions and contact details of relevant informants.

Provide links to any relevant publications or reports.

Current and potential future uses and sources of statistics on cooperatives

13. Do any of the agencies listed in the previous sections currently use statistics on cooperatives, or include statistics about cooperatives in publications such as annual reports or on their Websites?

If yes, provide the following information and relevant links to websites for each agency:

a. the source(s) of statistics used (name of data collection/survey and agency collecting the data);

b. the nature of the statistics used or compiled (e.g., number of cooperatives, employment in cooperatives, number of members ...);

c. the main purposes for which these statistics are used;

d. any publications, reports or web pages which include statistics about cooperatives.

14. Do any of these agencies have unmet needs for statistics about cooperatives?

In depth discussion with informants/experts may be needed to obtain complete information about unmet needs. This could include, for example, discussions on Government programmes, policy concerns and initiatives in relation to cooperatives and the extent to which these concerns could be informed or monitored by statistics on cooperatives that are not available.

Provide details of the nature and purpose of the statistics required by each agency.

15. Please summarize the national needs for statistics of cooperatives, based on the responses to questions 13 and 14.

16. Do any of the Government agencies or cooperative confederations listed in the previous sections conduct regular or occasional censuses or surveys of cooperatives for statistical or other purposes?

For each data collection, provide details of the name, date scope, variables included, and outputs produced.

17. Which agency or agencies have the main responsibility for official national statistics in the country?

Include agencies responsible for production of statistics such as the National Statistical Institute or Ministry of Planning and so forth, as well as agencies responsible for overseeing, coordinating, or approving national statistics, such as the national statistics authority or council.

Record the name(s) of agency (or agencies) responsible for national statistics and links to websites.

18. Are cooperatives, or employment in cooperatives, identifiable in any of the statistics compiled by this agency (or these agencies)?

Provide details of and links to any surveys, censuses, or statistical outputs in which information about cooperatives can be identified.

19. Does the register of businesses used to select the sample in establishment surveys identify cooperatives separately from other types of establishments?

20. What existing or planned data collections could potentially be used in the future to provide information about the economic and social impact of cooperatives, their memberships, and employment generated by cooperatives (for example, economic census, establishment surveys, labour force surveys, other types of household survey, administrative data collections)?

Annex 2
Checklist 2: Evaluation of existing and potential sources of information on cooperatives

The purpose of this checklist is to provide a framework to:

- gather information needed for evaluation of existing and potential sources of information on cooperatives;
- evaluate the extent to which existing and potential sources of information on cooperatives can be used in the compilation of statistics that comply with the ILO Guidelines and satisfy national needs for statistics on cooperatives;
- identify gaps in the required information and improvements or modifications needed.

The checklist is divided into two parts.

The first part considers the definition or definitions of cooperatives used in the country for legal and administrative purposes, and the types of cooperatives that are recognized in the country. It proposes comparison and mapping of these definitions to the definition and types of cooperatives specified in the Guidelines. This will allow users of the checklist to determine whether statistics compiled from data sources that use these definitions are fully compliant with the international Guidelines.

The second part considers whether the concepts and statistical outputs specified in the Guidelines, or required for national purposes, are included in or can be derived from each of the data sources identified in Checklist 1 to identify the landscape and national requirements for statistics of cooperatives.

Definitions and types of cooperatives

1. Are the definitions or criteria used in the country to identify cooperatives for legal and administrative purposes consistent with the reference concept of "cooperative" specified in paragraph 6 of the Guidelines as:

an autonomous association of persons and/or legal entities united voluntarily to meet their common economic, social and cultural needs and aspirations through a jointly owned and democratically controlled enterprise?

Explain any significant differences from this definition for each of the definitions or criteria used at the national level. Information about definitions or criteria used for the identification of cooperatives was collected in Checklist 1 through questions 3, 4, 8c, 9b and 10b.

- *Note: If the definitions used for national purposes are not consistent with the international definition provided in the Guidelines, the statistics for national purposes should in principle be based on the national definition. However, the national reports should mention any such cases and assess any likely impact on international comparability, as well as making any recommendations considered appropriate with respect to national policies or modifications to the Guidelines.*

2. Do these definitions or the criteria used to identify cooperatives include any or all of the operational criteria for the definition of cooperatives specified in paragraph 19 of the Guidelines?

(i) A cooperative should be a formally established institutional unit (non-financial corporation, financial corporation or non-profit institution);

(ii) A cooperative should be controlled democratically by its members according to the principle that each member has an equal vote;

(iii) Membership of the cooperative should be voluntary and non-restrictive;

(iv) Distribution of profits or surpluses among the members is not directly linked to the capital contributed by each member.

Explain which, if any, of these criteria are used.

3. Are any additional criteria used to identify cooperatives?

If yes, please specify.

4. Are any organizations that are not to be counted as cooperatives according to the Guidelines (para 21), such as mutual societies, self-help groups or social ventures as defined in the SNA (paras 23.21, 23.34. and 23.25), considered to be cooperative according to national definitions and criteria?

5. How should each of the national types and sub-types of cooperatives (identified in Checklist 1 question 11) be mapped to the four main types of cooperatives distinguished in paragraph 12 of the Guidelines?

- Producer cooperatives
- Worker cooperatives
- Consumer/user cooperatives
- Multi-stakeholder cooperatives

Data sources

6. Can the concepts and statistical outputs specified in the Guidelines, or required for national purposes, be derived from relevant data sources identified?

Relevant data sources include administrative and statistical registers of businesses maintained by Government agencies (including national statistical offices) and Cooperative Confederations, censuses and surveys of businesses, and census and surveys of households. Basic information about relevant data collections was requested in Checklist 1, questions 7, 8, 9, 10, 16, 18, 19 and 20.

For each of the data sources identified in Checklist 1, please answer the following questions for the most recently available data.

7. What types of units are the data collected from (for example enterprises, establishments, agricultural holdings, households)?

8. What is the scope of the data collection or administrative register (for example, all establishments in the country, cooperatives registered with the agency compiling the data, all households)?

9. Does the source include observations for all units in scope or a sample?

10. If sampling is used, please provide relevant information about the sample, such as sample size and fraction, the sampling frame and selection methods, coverage (including geographic localities, urban/rural, etc), representativity (are inferences possible or not). Any potential limitations on the reliability of estimates for statistics of cooperative deriving from the sampling methodology should be identified.

11. Frequency of data collection, for example annual, monthly, irregular, once only.

12. Reference period of most recently collected or available data.

For surveys, censuses and administrative data collected from businesses (enterprises, establishments, agricultural holdings, cooperatives and so forth) please answer the following questions.

13. Does the data source identify cooperatives as distinct from other types of enterprise?

14. If cooperatives are identified, what methods are used to differentiate them from other types of enterprise?

15. What modifications to the data source and/or collection methods would be needed to identify, or improve the identification of, cooperatives in accordance with the Guidelines?

16. Does the source identify different types of cooperatives, and if so, what types or subtypes are identified?

17. Does the source include information that could be used, or potentially be used, to identify non-cooperative subsidiaries of cooperatives? For example, if the source is a commercial register, does it include information on ownership structures that could show that an enterprise is a wholly owned subsidiary, or identify the assets held by the enterprise, including other enterprises?

18. Does the data source include information about members and membership of cooperatives, and if so, what information is available about the characteristics of those member (for example age, sex, type of membership)?

19. What information included in the data source could be used to assess the economic contribution and performance of cooperatives, including:

- **a.** employment
- **b.** revenue
- **c.** value added
- **d.** assets
- **e.** liabilities
- **f.** the use of profits or surpluses
- **g.** investment
- **h.** earnings of workers within the scope of statistics on cooperatives
- **i.** share of transactions with members and non-members
- **j.** value received
- **k.** value shared
- **l.** value of volunteer work
- **m.** patronage refunds
- **n.** share of intermediate consumption with member
- **o.** other measures of economic performance

20. What, if any, information is available in the data source about the characteristics of persons working in cooperatives, such as age, sex, hours worked and earnings?

For surveys, censuses and administrative data collected from households and persons, please answer the following questions.

21. Does the data source include any information about whether a person is a member of a cooperative?

22. What modifications would be needed to allow or improve the identification of members of cooperatives in accordance with the Guidelines?

23. Would it potentially be feasible to collect information about the types (or a specific type) of cooperative of which the person is a member, for example, whether the person is a member of a housing cooperative, or an agricultural producers' cooperative?

24. Does the data source include any information about employment or other forms of work in cooperatives? If yes, please elaborate?

25. Does the data source include information about the institutional sector in which persons are employed?

26. What modifications to the institutional sector question(s) or other questions could potentially be used to allow or improve the identification of employment in accordance with the Guidelines?

27. What other information available in the data source could be used to compile statistics on the characteristics of members of cooperatives and persons employed in cooperatives as specified in paras 37 and 38 of the Guidelines?

- **a.** sex
- **b.** age group
- **c.** geographical region
- **d.** urban and rural area
- **e.** type of member
- **f.** status in employment
- **g.** occupation
- **h.** economic activity of the cooperative
- **i.** other relevant variables

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